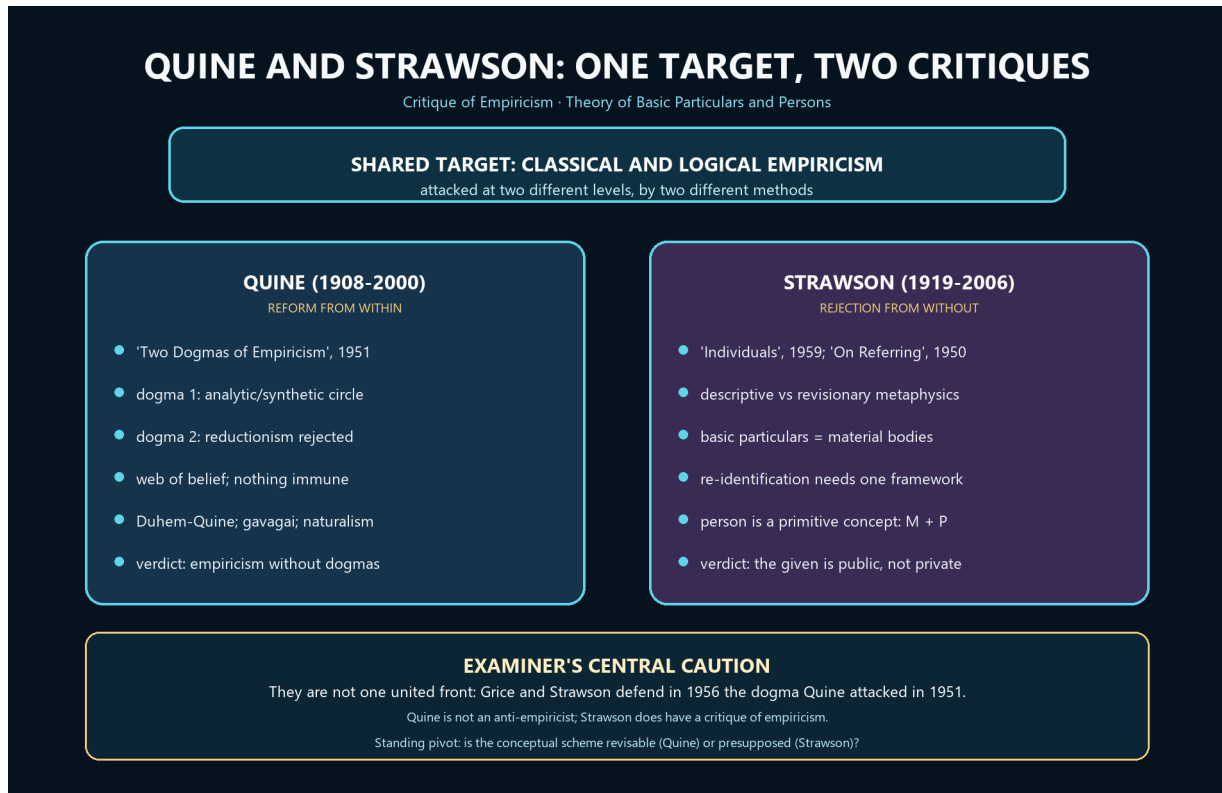


# Quine and Strawson - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



*Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.*

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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# Quine and Strawson - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

## BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

### RAPID REVISION 1 - Two-Project Map - One Syllabus Heading, Two Philosophers, Two Different Critiques of Empiricism

#### Rapid recall

- **One target (empiricism), two different critiques:** Quine reforms the *epistemology* (holism); Strawson rejects the *starting point* (sense-data).
- **Quine side:** "Two Dogmas" (1951) - analytic/synthetic distinction and reductionism both fail; positive doctrine = confirmation holism / web of belief; "no statement is immune to revision"; "to be = value of a bound variable" (On What There Is, 1948).
- **Strawson side:** *Individuals* (1959) - descriptive metaphysics; basic particulars = material bodies; person = primitive (M + P predicates); "On Referring" (1950) - presupposition vs Russell.
- **They clash:** Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956), defend the distinction Quine attacks - so they are not one united front.
- **Mnemonic:** "Quine kills TWO dogmas; Strawson saves TWO Ps."
- **Trap:** treating "Quine-Strawson" as one doctrine, or giving Strawson no critique of empiricism (see subtopic 9).
- **Ownership:** 9 owned parts 2018-2025, none in 2022.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 1-4; frames every PYQ.

### RAPID REVISION 2 - Quine, Dogma 1 - The Analytic/Synthetic Distinction and the Circle of Synonymy

#### Rapid recall

- **Positivist division:** analytic = true by meaning (no experience needed); synthetic = true by fact.
- **The circle (A-M-S-D-I-S):** analytic -> meaning -> synonymy -> definition (only records synonymy) / interchangeability *salva veritate* (needs necessity = analyticity) / semantic rules (defined via "analytic-in-L"). Every route is **circular**.
- **Exact conclusion:** no *principled, non-circular* boundary; difference of **degree** (centrality in the web), not of **kind**. NOT "analytic truths don't exist".
- **salva veritate trap:** in a purely extensional language "creature with a heart" / "creature with a kidney" are interchangeable but not synonymous - so interchangeability needs intensional *necessity*, which begs the question.
- **Reply:** Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) - usable distinction without a definition. **Rejoinder:** usability is not theoretical legitimacy.
- **Provenance:** "Two Dogmas", *Philosophical Review*, Jan 1951 (revised 1953). Circle = first half; holism = section 6.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 5-8; PYQ 2019 Q1(e); feeds 2024 Q4(c) and 2021 Q3(c).

### RAPID REVISION 3 - Quine, Dogma 2 and the Positive Doctrine - Reductionism Rejected, Confirmation Holism and the Web of Belief

#### Rapid recall

- **Dogma 2 = reductionism:** each sentence has its own private confirming experiences and is verifiable in isolation. **False.**
- **Positive doctrine = confirmation holism:** "statements face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**"; the **web of belief / field of force**; experience touches the **periphery**; interior = maths, logic.

- **Two doctrine-lines:** "any statement can be held true **come what may**" (adjust elsewhere) and "**no statement is immune to revision**" (not even logic).
- **Consequences:** no sharp analytic/synthetic or a priori/a posteriori line; theory-choice is **pragmatic** (simplicity, conservatism, fecundity); the **verification principle collapses** (it needed individual verifiability).
- **2025 quotation is holism, not relativism:** the conditional clause ("adjustments elsewhere") is the doctrine; **minimum mutilation** (*Philosophy of Logic*, 1970) blocks "anything goes".
- **Trap:** "web of belief = all beliefs equally revisable." No - periphery bends first, logic last, but none is immune in principle.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 9-12; PYQ 2025 Q4(b); feeds 2024 Q4(c) and 2021 Q3(c).

## RAPID REVISION 4 - The Duhem-Quine Thesis - Why No Single Hypothesis Faces Experience Alone

### Rapid recall

- **Thesis:** a hypothesis is tested only with auxiliaries; **(H & A) → O; not-O ⇒ not-(H & A)**; logic never says which conjunct - so refutation is not decisive.
- **Split (do not merge):** **Duhem** (1906) - physics only, logic/maths **exempt**, no *experimentum crucis*; **Quine** (1951) - **whole of science**, logic **included**, underdetermination + collapse of verification.
- **Two examples together:** **Neptune** (revise auxiliary, right, 1846) and **Vulcan** (revise auxiliary, wrong → general relativity 1915). Same logic, opposite correct responses.
- **Replies:** **Popper** - falsification is a methodological decision, not automatic logic; **Lakatos** - hard core + protective belt (research programmes).
- **Payoff:** this is the engine of holism and the reason "any statement can be held true come what may".
- **Trap:** writing "Duhem and Quine hold the same thesis" (they do not); presenting Popper as denying the logical point.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 13-16; underwrites PYQ 2025 Q4(b) and 2021 Q3(c).

## RAPID REVISION 5 - Radical Translation and 'Gavagai' - Inscrutability of Reference and Indeterminacy of Translation

### Rapid recall

- **Radical translation:** no dictionary/interpreter; evidence = stimulation + assent/dissent only. Source: *Word and Object* (1960), ch. 2.
- **Gavagai rivals (same stimulus meaning):** rabbit / **undetached rabbit-parts** / temporal rabbit-stage / rabbithood / "it is rabbiting" (no object).
- **The identity move:** "same gavagai?" needs the **apparatus of individuation** (identity predicate, articles, plurals) - itself undetermined.
- **Two results:** **inscrutability of reference** → **indeterminacy of translation** (rival **analytical hypotheses** agree on all observation sentences); hence no determinate **meanings**; **ontological relativity** ("at home" we take our tongue at face value).
- **Premises:** P1 behaviourism about evidence; P2 verificationism about facts (the *irony* - kept as factuality, dropped as meaning); P3 naturalism.
- **Objections:** **Chomsky** (just underdetermination - name the asymmetry and rule); **Davidson** (radical *interpretation*, harmless indeterminacy).
- **Trap:** "meanings are indeterminate" as a bare slogan; forgetting the behaviourist premise carries the whole argument.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 17-20; enriches PYQ 2019 Q1(e), 2024 Q4(c), 2021 Q3(c).

## RAPID REVISION 6 - Ontological Commitment, Naturalized Epistemology and Ontological Relativity - and Quine's Convergence with the Later Wittgenstein

### Rapid recall

- **Ontological commitment:** "to be is to be the value of a bound variable" (**On What There Is, 1948**, not Two Dogmas); read ontology off the quantifiers of regimented best science.
- **Naturalized epistemology:** philosophy continuous with science, "a chapter of psychology" (**1968/69**); study sensory input -> theoretical output.
- **Ontological relativity:** reference fixed only relative to a background language; no God's-eye "what really exists?"; "at home" we take our tongue at face value.
- **Quine <-> later Wittgenstein:** converge (reject museum myth / Augustinian picture; holism; anti-foundationalism - **Neurath's boat** vs "my spade is turned"; reject the private); **part** on method - Quine **reforms** (regimentation), Wittgenstein **describes** ("in order as it is").
- **Relation to empiricism:** NOT rejected - **empiricism without the dogmas** (holistic; experience governs belief, not sentence-by-sentence).
- **2018 a-priori charge:** circle + holism + naturalism => the a priori is "a metaphysical article of faith".
- **Trap:** dating naturalised epistemology to 1951; treating Quine as anti-empiricist; merging his convergence with Wittgenstein into identity of view.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 21-24; home of PYQ 2018 Q2(c).

## RAPID REVISION 7 - Strawson's Basic Particulars - Material Bodies and the Single Spatio-Temporal Framework

### Rapid recall

- **Descriptive vs revisionary metaphysics:** describe the scheme we actually use (Aristotle, Kant) vs replace it (Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley). *Individuals* (**1959**) = "An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics".
- **Basic particular:** identifiable **without** first identifying anything else; **material bodies** qualify (three-dimensional, enduring, publicly located).
- **The argument:** objective thought needs **re-identification** -> needs a **single unified spatio-temporal system** -> bodies constitute it -> bodies are basic; other particulars depend on them (**conceptual** dependence).
- **No-space world:** purely **auditory** world can re-identify only by building a space-analogue ("master-sound") -> supports the thesis.
- **2020 link:** spatio-temporal thinking is a **precondition of objective thinking** (seems/is distinction), not merely a way to locate things.
- **Provenance:** *Individuals* 1959 (not *The Bounds of Sense* 1966); the auditory world is Strawson's, not Kant's.
- **Trap:** "bodies are basic because solid/obvious" (miss re-identification); calling descriptive metaphysics a rejection of metaphysics.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 25-28; home of PYQ 2020 Q3(b) and 2021 Q3(b).

## RAPID REVISION 8 - Strawson's Persons - The Primitive Concept, M/P-Predicates, and the Block on Dualism

### Rapid recall

- **Thesis:** the concept **person** is **primitive** - logically prior to, not composed from, the concepts of pure mind and pure body.
- **Predicate matrix:** **M-predicates** (weight, location - also of mere bodies) + **P-predicates** (pain, belief, action - only of persons). P-predicates are **asymmetric**: to others by behavioural criteria, to oneself without observation.
- **Argument:** **self-ascription requires other-ascription** -> requires identifying others as single M+P subjects -> person is primitive.
- **Blocks dualism:** two independent substances cannot be the one subject of both predicate-kinds; dualism makes other minds unknowable and P-ascription unlearnable.

- **Blocks no-ownership theory:** (Lichtenberg's "it thinks") self-refutes - "my experiences" cannot be eliminated without reintroducing ownership.
- **Not logical behaviourism:** behaviour is *critical evidence*, not the *meaning* of P-predicates.
- **Provenance:** *Individuals* (1959), ch. 3 "Persons".
- **Trap:** stopping at "person is basic so no dualism" (run the argument); omitting the no-ownership half; collapsing Strawson into behaviourism.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 29-32; home of PYQ 2018 Q1(e) and 2023 Q4(a).

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## RAPID REVISION 9 - 'On Referring' versus Russell, and Strawson as a Critic of Empiricism

### Rapid recall

- **"On Referring" (Strawson, 1950, Mind) vs Russell's Theory of Descriptions ("On Denoting", 1905).**
- **Who refers:** sentences do not refer; **people refer** in a **use** on an occasion. "The" is a referring device, not (Russell's) hidden quantifier.
- **Empty subject "the present King of France is bald":** Russell -> **FALSE** (existence asserted and fails); Strawson -> **neither true nor false**, a **truth-value gap** (a **presupposition** fails).
- **Three levels:** sentence (meaning = rules for use) / use (truth-value arises) / utterance.
- **Russell's reply:** bivalence and elimination of denoting phrases serve a formal logic - the aim differs (regimentation vs description); note Quine would side with Russell.
- **Strawson as critic of empiricism (syllabus phrase covers BOTH names):** the **given is public**, not private sense-data; identification needs a public spatio-temporal framework -> the empiricist *starting point* is incoherent. Quine reforms empiricism from within; Strawson challenges its starting point from without.
- **Provenance:** On Referring **1950**; On Denoting **1905**; do not merge, do not simply credit Frege.
- **Trap:** saying "the sentence is false" in Strawson's voice; treating On Referring as owning a PYQ; ignoring the critic-of-empiricism reading of Strawson.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 33-36; enriches PYQ 2020 Q3(b) and 2021 Q3(b).

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## RAPID REVISION 10 - Synthesis - Quine versus Strawson, Their Convergences, and the Universal Answer Spine

### Rapid recall

- **Same enemy, opposite ends:** both target **classical empiricism** - Quine from *within* epistemology (analyticity, holism), Strawson at its *starting point* (the private given).
- **Core clash (one question):** conceptual scheme **REVISABLE** "come what may" (Quine) vs **INDISPENSABLE / a precondition** of objective thought (Strawson).
- **Method mirrors it: naturalism** (continuous with science) vs **descriptive metaphysics** (transcendental strain).
- **Convergences (score with these):** both **anti-Cartesian / anti-private-object**; both anchor in the **public / holistic** (web of belief // public spatio-temporal framework); both reject the **museum myth** of determinate private meanings (with later Wittgenstein).
- **Do not overstate:** they differ on status, meaning and method - convergence is in *target and temper*, not doctrine.
- **Universal spine:** decode+owner -> thesis -> mechanism(exact term) -> objection->reply(named) -> graded verdict(+clean date).
- **Graded close:** periphery is Quineanly revisable; the framework role looks Strawsonianly indispensable - the truth is layered.
- **Trap:** "they basically agree"; importing Logical Positivism / Empiricism / Kant as owner here.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 37-40; the spine underwrites all nine solved PYQs.

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## CANONICAL EXAM APPARATUS (PRESERVED VERBATIM)

The examiner apparatus below is reproduced verbatim from the canonical Quine-Strawson.md (headings demoted, navigation links stripped). It is preserved intact so that no canonical depth - criticisms and replies, common traps, the keyword and statement bank, the restored 2018/2020 dossier, the corpus depth delta, PYQ routing, answer architecture, inter-thinker debates, the directive decoder, the graded verdict bank, quotation / dating / provenance discipline, link-outs and sources - is lost in the layered reorganisation.

## Criticisms and Replies

### VISUAL - 5.1 Criticisms of Quine

| Objection                                                                                                                                        | Assessment                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Grice &amp; Strawson:</b> The distinction is pre-theoretically clear; we <i>can</i> sort cases. Quine demands too much (reductive definition) | ANALYSIS: This is a live debate. Quine's point is that <i>philosophical work</i> done by the distinction (e.g. positivist meaning-criterion) collapses without a principled ground.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Analyticity seems real:</b> "All bachelors are unmarried" <i>seems</i> different in kind from "All swans are white"                           | Quine accepts the <i>appearance</i> but explains it away as difference of <i>degree</i> (centrality in the web), not kind.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Revisability of logic is extreme:</b> Has anyone ever <i>actually</i> revised a law of logic?                                                 | ANALYSIS: FACT: <b>Get the history right.</b> The <b>non-classical "quantum logic"</b> - a non-distributive lattice of propositions - was proposed by <b>Garrett Birkhoff and John von Neumann</b> , "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics," <i>Annals of Mathematics</i> , <b>1936</b> . The claim that this shows <b>logic is empirical</b> , i.e. that the <b>distributive law</b> should be revised on empirical grounds, is <b>Hilary Putnam's</b> , in "Is Logic Empirical?" ( <b>1968</b> ; reprinted as "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics," 1976). WRONG: Do not write "Putnam/Birkhoff" as a joint proposal, and do not date it to one year. CAUTION: <b>Two further nuances worth a clause each:</b> (i) <b>Putnam later abandoned</b> the quantum-logic realism of that paper; (ii) <b>Quine himself grew conservative</b> - in <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> (1970) he argues that anyone who "denies" a law of logic has merely changed the subject (" <b>change of logic, change of subject</b> ") and invokes the <b>maxim of minimum mutilation</b> . So the strongest textual support for revising logic comes from Putnam, not Quine, and the <i>later</i> Quine is a poor witness for the <i>earlier</i> Quine's most radical claim. <b>Deploying this makes an ordinary answer look researched.</b> |
| <b>Holism is too extreme:</b> If <i>everything</i> is revisable, science has no fixed point at all - is this coherent?                           | ANALYSIS: Quine softens: logic/math's are revisable <i>in principle</i> but held fixed in practice (by pragmatic conservatism). The point is no statement is revisable by <i>nature</i> , only by <i>choice</i> .                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |



## VISUAL - 5.2 Criticisms of Strawson

| Objection                                                                                                                                                                  | Assessment                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Is "person is primitive" an explanation or a re-labelling?</b><br>Saying the concept is unanalysable might simply refuse to address the hard problem of consciousness.  | ANALYSIS: Strawson's defenders: the point is that <i>the demand for analysis</i> (into mind + body) presupposes dualism. Refusing analysis IS the solution - dissolving the question rather than answering it.    |
| <b>The basic-particulars argument is too anthropocentric:</b> Maybe <i>our</i> scheme needs bodies, but a divine or radically alien mind might not.                        | ANALYSIS: Strawson acknowledges this: descriptive metaphysics describes <i>our</i> scheme - it does not claim universality.                                                                                       |
| <b>How does the person really unify mental and physical?</b> Merely calling it "primitive" does not explain the psychophysical nexus.                                      | CAUTION: Genuine limitation. Strawson does not explain the <i>mechanism</i> of unity - only that our concept of a person is not <i>derivable</i> from separate concepts of mind and body.                         |
| <b>Strawson vs Russell on descriptions:</b> Russell's view is logically cleaner and handles empty descriptions without the need for "presupposition" as a technical notion | ANALYSIS: Live debate. Russell handles scope (primary/secondary occurrence); Strawson better captures ordinary intuition about King-of-France sentences ("it's neither true nor false" rather than "it's false"). |

## VISUAL - Common UPSC Traps

| Trap                                                           | Discrimination                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Quine <i>rejects</i> empiricism"                              | No - he reforms it <i>from within</i> . He is a <i>better</i> empiricist (holistic, without dogmas).                                                                                                                                             |
| "Quine says analytic truths don't exist"                       | Not exactly. He says the <i>distinction</i> (analytic vs synthetic) cannot be drawn principledly. Some truths are <i>very central</i> in the web and very unlikely to be revised - but this is a matter of degree, not a categorical difference. |
| "Strawson's 'person is primitive' = dualism"                   | <b>Exactly wrong.</b> "Primitive" means the person is NOT decomposable into mind + body. It <i>blocks</i> dualism.                                                                                                                               |
| "Strawson's 'person is primitive' = materialism"               | Also wrong. A person has <i>both</i> M-predicates and P-predicates; it is not a mere body. Materialism (identifying persons with bodies alone) loses P-predicates.                                                                               |
| "Quine is a logical positivist"                                | No. He is the positivists' most devastating <i>internal</i> critic. He accepts empiricism but rejects both pillars on which positivism stood.                                                                                                    |
| "Basic particulars = atoms / ultimate simples"                 | No. Basic particulars are <i>macroscopic</i> material bodies and persons - the things we actually identify and re-identify in ordinary experience. Not microphysical.                                                                            |
| "Web of belief = all beliefs are equally likely to be revised" | No. Peripheral beliefs (close to experience) are revised first and most easily; central beliefs (logic) are revised last and only under extreme pressure. But <i>no</i> belief is unrevisable in principle.                                      |
| "'On Referring' is part of the syllabus"                       | Not directly - the syllabus says "Critique of Empiricism; Basic Particulars and Persons." But "On Referring" illustrates Strawson's method and is often asked in combination with Russell (who IS in the syllabus).                              |

## Keyword and Statement Bank

| # | Item                                                                                                                                         | Use                 |
|---|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| 1 | FACT: "Our statements about the external world face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body." - Quine | Confirmation holism |

| #  | Item                                                                                                                         | Use                                              |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 2  | FACT: "Any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system." - Quine | No statement immune - web of belief (2025 Q4(b)) |
| 3  | FACT: "No statement is immune to revision." - Quine                                                                          | Corollary of holism                              |
| 4  | FACT: "The concept of a person is logically prior to that of an individual consciousness." - Strawson                        | Person as primitive                              |
| 5  | ANALYSIS: Descriptive metaphysics = "content to describe the actual structure of our thought about the world" - Strawson     | Opening move of <i>Individuals</i>               |
| 6  | ANALYSIS: "To be is to be the value of a bound variable." - Quine                                                            | Ontological commitment criterion                 |
| 7  | ANALYSIS: Circle of synonymy-definition-interchangeability-semantic rules                                                    | How Dogma 1 fails                                |
| 8  | ANALYSIS: M-predicates (material) + P-predicates (personal)                                                                  | Structure of the person concept                  |
| 9  | ANALYSIS: Basic particulars = material bodies + persons                                                                      | Strawson's ontology                              |
| 10 | ANALYSIS: Presupposition (Strawson) vs assertion (Russell) of existence                                                      | "On Referring" vs "On Denoting"                  |

## Restored 2018 / 2020 Doctrine Dossier

### Quine and the a priori as an "article of faith"

- FACT: Quine attacks the analytic/synthetic distinction needed to isolate truths held independently of experience. Definitions, synonymy and analyticity form a circle unless grounded in a non-question-begging behavioural or semantic criterion.
- FACT: Holism makes revision a matter of degree and convenience across the web of belief; even logic faces revision in principle, although central statements are protected in practice.
- CAUTION: **Objection** -> **reply**: revisability does not show that every proposition has the same status. Quine replies with gradients of entrenchment rather than a sharp a priori boundary.

### Strawson: spatio-temporal identification

- FACT: Objective thought requires a public framework in which enduring material bodies can be reidentified across places and times. Persons are basic because both physical and mental predicates apply to the same reidentifiable subjects.
- ANALYSIS: The framework is a condition of our conceptual scheme, not a psychological image or an inference from private sense-data.

### Corpus-Driven Depth Delta

- ANALYSIS: **Priority**: Primary ownership rises to 9 of 112 parts; 2022 remains the only year without an owned part.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth**: The restored papers add Strawson's person concept, spatio-temporal identification of basic particulars and Quine's charge that Kantian a priori knowledge becomes a "metaphysical article of faith".
- WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence**: Do not treat Strawson's spatio-temporal scheme as merely empirical psychology or Quine's naturalism as the rejection of every revisable conceptual distinction.

### PYQ Routing Table

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal**: 9 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

| Year | Question | Marks    | Exact demand                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------|----------|----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2018 | Q1(e)    | 10 marks | How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss.                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 2018 | Q2(c)    | 15 marks | How does Quine show that the notion of a priori knowledge as discussed by Kant is 'a metaphysical article of faith'? Give reasons for your answer.                                                                                           |
| 2019 | Q1(e)    | 10 marks | Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction.                                                                                                                                                                            |
| 2020 | Q3(b)    | 15 marks | Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars.                                                                                                                |
| 2021 | Q3(b)    | 15 marks | What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss.                                                                |
| 2021 | Q3(c)    | 15 marks | Critically examine Quine's postulate of empiricism without the dogmas with reference to his 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.                                                                                                                      |
| 2023 | Q4(a)    | 20 marks | Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss.                                                                                                               |
| 2024 | Q4(c)    | 15 marks | Explain the nature of the two dogmas that Quine refers to in his paper 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.                                                                                                                                           |
| 2025 | Q4(b)    | 15 marks | "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." Discuss this statement in the light of Quine's 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'. |

See the Western Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

### Answer Architecture Templates

#### 10-mark: "Explain Quine's arguments against the analytic-synthetic distinction." (2019)

State : Logical positivists distinguish analytic (true by meaning) from synthetic (true by fact).

Quine : "Analytic" cannot be non-circularly defined:  
analytic -> synonymy -> definition -> presupposes synonymy (CIRCULAR);  
or -> interchangeability salva veritate -> requires "necessity" -> presupposes analyticity (CIRCULAR);  
or -> semantic rules of L -> "analytic-in-L" -> presupposes what we want to define.

Result : The distinction is a dogma - difference of degree (centrality in web), not kind.

Assess : Grice & Strawson reply: we can sort cases pre-theoretically.  
Quine: pre-theoretical sorting ≠ principled philosophical distinction.

#### 15-mark: "Discuss quotation on holism - web of belief." (2025)

Frame : Quine, "Two Dogmas" - after demolishing both the analytic/synthetic distinction and reductionism, offers confirmation HOLISM as the positive replacement.

Expo : (i) Statements face experience as a "corporate body," not individually.  
(ii) Web metaphor: experience touches the periphery; interior = logic, maths.  
(iii) Conflict at the edge -> choice about where to revise.  
(iv) "Any statement can be held true come what may" - revise elsewhere.  
(v) "No statement is immune to revision" - not even logic.

Consequence: No sharp analytic/synthetic or a priori/a posteriori line.  
Theory-choice is pragmatic (simplicity, conservatism, fecundity).  
Positivist meaning-criterion collapses.

Assess : Strengths - dissolves positivist dogmatism; captures actual scientific practice (Newtonian revision; the Neptune/Vulcan pair; the quantum-logic debate opened by Birkhoff-von Neumann 1936 and pressed as an \*empirical\* revision of logic by Putnam 1968).  
Weakness - if logic is revisable, what constrains rational belief? Risk of "anything goes" (mitigated by Quine's pragmatic conservatism).

Close : Holism liberates empiricism from atomism - the "web" is a more faithful model of knowledge than the "bucket" (individual sentence -> experience pairs).

#### 20-mark: "Why does Strawson consider person a primitive concept? Implications for dualism." (2023)

Frame : The mind-body problem: Descartes = two substances; no-ownership = no subject; Strawson rejects BOTH - proposes person as logically primitive.

Body-A : Descriptive metaphysics - describe our actual conceptual scheme.  
In our scheme, we identify persons as single entities bearing BOTH M-predicates (material: "weighs 70 kg") AND P-predicates (personal: "is in pain").

Body-B : The argument from other-ascription: to self-ascribe pain, I must be able to ascribe it to OTHERS (public meaningfulness condition). I identify others as persons - embodied subjects - by observing behaviour. P-predicates have DUAL character: ascribable to self without observation, to others on the basis of observation. This is possible only if the subject is a PERSON - not a pure mind.

Body-C : Implication for dualism: dualism DECOMPOSES person into mind + body and then cannot put them together (interaction problem). Strawson: person is NOT composed of two substances; it is LOGICALLY PRIOR to both "mind" and "body." The decomposition is illicit - person is the unanalysable starting point. Also blocks no-ownership: if no subject, P-predicates lose their sense (you cannot deny what you need to state the denial).

Assess : Strengths - dissolves the problem by refusing its dualist premise; faithful to how we actually use "person" in ordinary life and law.  
Weaknesses - does not explain HOW the person unifies mental and physical (the "hard problem"); "primitive" may be a name for the mystery, not its solution. Still, as descriptive metaphysics it is powerful - dualism's question may simply be ill-formed.

Close : The person is not mind-plus-body; it is what makes attributing both minds and bodies intelligible. Strawson does not solve the mind-body problem - he dissolves the premise that generates it.

## Directive Decoder

| Directive                                                                                    | What it demands                                                                 | Structural obligation for this file                                                                                                                                                      | Fatal error                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Critique of empiricism - discuss</b>                                                      | <b>both</b> names, and two <i>different</i> critiques                           | Quine: internal reform (holism replaces atomism). Strawson: external attack on the starting point (§3.6).                                                                                | Giving Quine only.                                |
| <b>Comment on the quotation</b><br>(2025 Q4b "any statement can be held true come what may") | the <b>conditional clause</b> is the doctrine                                   | Explain via Duhem-Quine: <i>modus tollens</i> condemns only the conjunction, so the choice of what to revise is not evidential. Then the Neptune/Vulcan pair.                            | Quoting the first half and calling it relativism. |
| <b>Examine the analytic/synthetic distinction</b> (2025, 2024, 2021, 2019)                   | the <b>circle of synonymy</b> as a <i>chain</i> , then the positive alternative | Analytic -> meaning -> synonymy -> definition -> interchangeability <i>salva veritate</i> -> semantical rules -> back to analyticity. Then Grice-Strawson's reply and Quine's rejoinder. | Asserting the distinction "cannot be defined."    |
| <b>Explain the theory of basic particulars</b> (2021 Q3b)                                    | show why they are <b>basic</b> , i.e. an argument from identification           | Re-identification requires a single spatio-temporal framework; sense-data are private, momentary and non-spatial; therefore material bodies.                                             | Listing what a basic particular is.               |
| <b>Discuss the theory of persons</b> (2023 Q4a, 2021 Q3b)                                    | the <b>primitiveness</b> argument, against <b>two</b> rivals                    | M-predicates and P-predicates; the argument that P-predicates must be ascribable to self and others alike; then Cartesian dualism <i>and</i> the no-ownership theory refuted.            | Refuting only dualism.                            |
| <b>Distinguish descriptive from revisionary metaphysics</b>                                  | give Strawson's <b>own</b> examples and the point of the distinction            | Descriptive: Aristotle, Kant. Revisionary: Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley. Point: revisionary metaphysics is in the service of descriptive.                                                | Two definitions with no examples.                 |
| <b>Assess indeterminacy of translation</b>                                                   | the <b>gavagai</b> construction, then the behaviourist premise                  | Rival manuals; the identity-predicate move; then Chomsky's underdetermination objection and take a side.                                                                                 | Asserting "meanings are indeterminate."           |

| Directive                    | What it demands              | Structural obligation for this file                                                                                               | Fatal error      |
|------------------------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Do you agree? / Substantiate | a ruling in line 1, defended | E.g. "Quine's holism succeeds against reductionism and overreaches about logic - as his own <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> concedes." | Neutral summary. |

### Graded Verdict Bank

| Sub-topic                            | 10-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                        | 15-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                       | 20-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Analytic/synthetic</b>            | Quine does not show the distinction is unintelligible; he shows it cannot be given a <b>non-circular</b> explanation, which is fatal only to the philosophical work it was made to do. | ...Grice and Strawson are right that we can sort clear cases and wrong that this suffices, since the positivists needed analyticity as a <i>foundation</i> , not as a rough classification.                           | The dispute is about standards of explication, not about the phenomenon. Quine wins where the distinction was load-bearing - the verification principle, Carnap's internal/external questions, the linguistic theory of necessity - and loses where it was merely useful. That is why the distinction survives in ordinary semantic practice and has never been restored to its foundational role.                                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Holism / Duhem-Quine</b>          | Statements face experience as a corporate body, so no single statement is individually confirmable - which by itself destroys the second dogma.                                        | ...Duhem confined the thesis to physics and exempted logic and mathematics; Quine's extension to <i>all</i> knowledge is the controversial step, and it is what makes the analytic/synthetic collapse follow.         | Holism is right about confirmation and overstated about revisability. Quine's own later work concedes as much: <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> (1970) invokes the maxim of minimum mutilation and argues that to deny a law of logic is to change the subject. The defensible position is Duhem's thesis with Quine's motivation - testing is holistic, choice of revision is pragmatic, and logic is revisable in a sense so attenuated that nothing much follows from it.                                                                                              |
| <b>Radical translation / gavagai</b> | There is no fact of the matter about reference, because no behavioural evidence can fix the apparatus of individuation.                                                                | ...The argument's force is exactly proportional to its behaviourist premise about evidence, and Quine retains a verificationist criterion of <i>factuality</i> while rejecting verificationism about <i>meaning</i> . | Chomsky's objection identifies the pressure point: if underdetermination does not make physics factless, why does it make translation factless? Quine's asymmetry - that there is nothing beyond dispositions for a manual to be right about - is a naturalist thesis, not a result of the argument, so the argument establishes its conclusion only for those already persuaded of the naturalism. What survives independently is the negative result that use alone does not fix reference - a result the later Wittgenstein reaches by a wholly different route. |

| Sub-topic                               | 10-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                            | 15-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                   | 20-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Ontological commitment</b>           | "To be is to be the value of a bound variable" converts ontology from intuition-mongering into an audit of our best theory's quantifiers.                                  | ...It presupposes regimentation into first-order logic, so what a theory is committed to depends on how it is formalised - which is why ontological relativity follows.                                           | The criterion is Quine's most durable contribution and also the reason his ontology is deflationary: since reference is fixed only relative to a manual, "what there is" is answered within a theory and not about theories. This is the exact point at which Quine and Carnap converge despite Quine's attack - both end with ontology as an intra-theoretic question, though Quine denies himself Carnap's excuse for saying so.                                     |
| <b>Basic particulars</b>                | Material bodies are basic because identification and <b>re-identification</b> demand a single spatio-temporal framework that private, momentary sense-data cannot provide. | ...The argument is transcendental in form - from an undisputed fact about reference to its necessary conditions - which is why <i>Individuals</i> and <i>The Bounds of Sense</i> are one project.                 | The conclusion is about our <b>conceptual scheme</b> , not about mind-independent reality, and Strawson says so: his metaphysics is descriptive. An empiricist may therefore accept the whole argument as conceptual geography while denying that it settles ontology. Whether descriptive metaphysics can be more than a very good map of how we think is the standing question about Strawson's programme, and the honest answer is that he never claimed more.      |
| <b>Persons</b>                          | "Person" is a <b>primitive</b> concept: it is not compounded from a mind and a body, because both dualism and the no-ownership theory presuppose it.                       | ...The decisive argument is that P-predicates must be ascribable to others on behavioural grounds and to oneself not on those grounds; a concept with that dual condition cannot be constructed from either half. | Strawson defeats Cartesianism more economically than any argument from interaction: he does not ask how mind and body can interact but shows that the question presupposes a prior unity that neither term can supply. The cost is that "primitive" marks the end of analysis rather than an explanation - which is a legitimate result for descriptive metaphysics and an unsatisfying one for anybody who wanted the mind-body problem solved rather than dissolved. |
| <b>Strawson vs Russell on referring</b> | Existence is <b>presupposed</b> , not asserted; a sentence with a failed presupposition raises no question of truth or falsity.                                            | ...This is a claim about ordinary use, not a refutation of the logical analysis, which was never offered as a description of conversation.                                                                        | The two are answering different questions, and the enduring lesson is methodological: Russell asks what regimentation best serves logic and science; Strawson asks what our actual practice is. Both are legitimate, and the twentieth-century quarrel between ideal-language and ordinary-language analysis is largely a failure to notice that.                                                                                                                      |

### Quotation, Dating and Provenance Discipline

Both write in English, so the discipline here is dating, attribution and formula-accuracy - the commonest failures on this item are misattributed technical proposals.

| Item                       | Correct provenance                                                                                            | Caution                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" | <i>The Philosophical Review</i> , <b>January 1951</b> ; revised in <i>From a Logical Point of View</i> (1953) | ANALYSIS: The famous "web of belief" / "field of force" passage is §6, "Empiricism without the Dogmas." Cite the section. |

| Item                                                    | Correct provenance                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Caution                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Any statement can be held true come what may..."       | "Two Dogmas," §6                                                                                                                                                                                                        | FACT: Safe verbatim. WRONG: Do not truncate it - the conditional clause ("if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system") is the doctrine.                                                                                                                                                                |
| "To be is to be the value of a bound variable"          | "On What There Is" ( <i>Review of Metaphysics</i> , 1948)                                                                                                                                                               | ANALYSIS: <b>Not</b> from "Two Dogmas." Separate paper, separate year.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <i>Word and Object</i>                                  | 1960                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Radical translation, gavagai, stimulus meaning, analytical hypotheses - <b>ch. 2</b> . FACT: The <b>epigraph is Neurath's boat</b> - cross-cite Logical-Positivism.md §P.                                                                                                                                                 |
| "Ontological Relativity"                                | Dewey Lectures, 1968; in <i>Ontological Relativity and Other Essays</i> (1969) - the same volume as "Epistemology Naturalized"                                                                                          | ANALYSIS: Do not date naturalised epistemology to 1951.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Quantum logic                                           | FACT: Birkhoff and von Neumann, "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics," <i>Annals of Mathematics</i> , 1936 - the formal proposal. FACT: Putnam, "Is Logic Empirical?", 1968 - the claim that logic is empirically revisable. | WRONG: <b>Never write "Putnam/Birkhoff" as a joint proposal, and never merge the dates.</b> CAUTION: Add that Putnam later abandoned the position, and that Quine's own <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> (1970) resists revision of logic via "change of logic, change of subject" and the <b>maxim of minimum mutilation</b> . |
| Duhem                                                   | <i>La Théorie physique: son objet, sa structure</i> (1906); Eng. <i>The Aim and Structure of Physical Theory</i> (tr. Wiener, 1954)                                                                                     | ANALYSIS: Duhem restricted the thesis to <b>physics</b> and exempted logic and mathematics. The label " <b>Duhem-Quine thesis</b> " is later shorthand for two <b>non-identical</b> claims - say so.                                                                                                                      |
| Popper                                                  | <i>Logik der Forschung</i> (1934); Eng. 1959                                                                                                                                                                            | ANALYSIS: Popper accepts the logical point and answers it methodologically; do not present him as denying Duhem-Quine.                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <i>Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics</i> | 1959                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Basic particulars Pt I; persons ch. 3; the subtitle contains the phrase "descriptive metaphysics" - quote the <b>subtitle</b> , it is exact.                                                                                                                                                                              |
| "On Referring"                                          | <i>Mind</i> , 1950                                                                                                                                                                                                      | ANALYSIS: Predates <i>Individuals</i> by nine years; it is not an application of descriptive metaphysics but its precursor.                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Grice & Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma"               | <i>The Philosophical Review</i> , 1956                                                                                                                                                                                  | ANALYSIS: <b>Co-authored with H. P. Grice</b> - attributing it to Strawson alone is a standard slip. Note also the spelling: <i>Defence</i> (British).                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <i>The Bounds of Sense</i>                              | 1966                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | The " <b>non-sequitur of numbing grossness</b> " charge against Kant's Second Analogy is here - see Kant .md §3.6.2. FACT: Safe verbatim; it is Strawson's own phrase.                                                                                                                                                    |
| <i>Introduction to Logical Theory</i>                   | 1952                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | The dissolution of the problem of induction, <b>ch. 9</b> .                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Chomsky's objection                                     | "Quine's Empirical Assumptions," in <i>Words and Objections</i> (1969)                                                                                                                                                  | FACT: Attribute the underdetermination objection to Chomsky, not to "critics."                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |



| Item     | Correct provenance                      | Caution                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Davidson | "Radical <b>Interpretation</b> " (1973) | ANALYSIS: <b>Interpretation</b> , not translation<br>- the change of word marks the change of doctrine (no shared observation-base assumed; charity and a truth-theory instead). |

WRONG: **Never write:** that Quine "rejected empiricism" (he calls his own position empiricism without the dogmas); that Strawson "defended empiricism" (he defends a distinction *against Quine*, which is not the same thing); that Duhem and Quine hold the same thesis; or that Quine denied the existence of meaning *tout court* rather than of meanings as determinate entities.

### Link-Outs to Related Topics

- Logical Positivism - the empiricism Quine reforms; the analytic/synthetic dogma he attacks; the verificationism he destroys.
- Kant - the synthetic a priori that Quine's holism blurs; the transcendental argument form Strawson revives.
- Moore-Russell-EarlyWittgenstein - Russell's theory of descriptions (which Strawson challenges in "On Referring"); logical analysis tradition both Quine and Strawson inherit.
- Later Wittgenstein - parallel critique of the picture/verification model of meaning; Strawson's "connective analysis" is closer to Wittgenstein's descriptive method than to Russell's reconstructive one.
- Empiricism - Hume's empiricism as the ancestor that Quine reforms.
- A priori / a posteriori - Quine erases the sharp a priori/a posteriori line.
- Substance across Western - Strawson's basic particulars as the modern "substance" question.
- Critiques of Metaphysics - Quine's holism as a solvent; Strawson's descriptive metaphysics as a *revival*.
- Self and Liberation - Strawson's person concept vs Indian *ātman/anātman* debates.
- Cross-paper: Notions of God - ontological commitment (Quine) bears on whether "God" is a value of a bound variable.
- PYQ bank: Western Philosophy PYQs, 2018-2025

### Sources

- W.V.O. Quine, "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951), reprinted in *From a Logical Point of View*.
- W.V.O. Quine, *Word and Object* (1960) - indeterminacy, ontological relativity.
- P.F. Strawson, *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics* (1959).
- P.F. Strawson, "On Referring" (1950) - the rival to Russell.
- H.P. Grice and P.F. Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) - reply to Quine.
- Y. Masih, *A Critical History of Western Philosophy* (Quine and Strawson chapters).
- Anthony Kenny, *A New History of Western Philosophy*, vol. 4.
- Roger Gibson, *The Philosophy of W.V. Quine* (overview of the system).
- A.C. Grayling (ed.), *Philosophy 2: Further Through the Subject* (Strawson's descriptive metaphysics).

## ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 48 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-40 are core coverage - four per subtopic across the ten subtopics; Questions 41-48 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 12 times.

### MCQ 1

In the syllabus item "Quine and Strawson", which pairing correctly matches each philosopher to his project?

- A. Quine - critique of empiricism; Strawson - theory of basic particulars and persons  
 B. Quine - theory of basic particulars and persons; Strawson - critique of empiricism  
 C. Both jointly propose a single naturalized theory of persons  
 D. Quine - descriptive metaphysics; Strawson - naturalized epistemology



**Correct answer: A** - Quine - critique of empiricism; Strawson - theory of basic particulars and persons

**Explanation:** Quine attacks empiricism from within ("Two Dogmas"); Strawson develops a descriptive metaphysics of basic particulars and persons. The two projects are kept distinct.

### MCQ 2

What single target do Quine and Strawson share, despite their different methods?

A. Kant's transcendental idealism B. Classical / logical empiricism C. Hegelian absolute idealism D. Aristotelian substance metaphysics

**Correct answer: B** - Classical / logical empiricism

**Explanation:** Both are critics of empiricism - Quine reforms it from within (holism), Strawson challenges its private-given starting point.

### MCQ 3

Which statement best captures the methodological contrast between the two thinkers?

A. Both rely primarily on transcendental arguments B. Both are thoroughgoing naturalists C. Quine is a naturalist (philosophy continuous with science); Strawson is a descriptive metaphysician D. Quine is a descriptive metaphysician; Strawson is a naturalist

**Correct answer: C** - Quine is a naturalist (philosophy continuous with science); Strawson is a descriptive metaphysician

**Explanation:** Quine's method is naturalism; Strawson's is descriptive (as opposed to revisionary) metaphysics.

### MCQ 4

The claim "Quine reforms empiricism from within while Strawson rejects its starting point" means that:

A. Both abandon empiricism entirely and embrace rationalism B. Both take private sense-data as the basic given C. Quine denies that experience is any check on belief D. Quine keeps experience as the check but drops the two dogmas, whereas Strawson denies that the private given can be foundational

**Correct answer: D** - Quine keeps experience as the check but drops the two dogmas, whereas Strawson denies that the private given can be foundational

**Explanation:** Quine's residue is "empiricism without the dogmas"; Strawson holds the given is public (bodies, persons), not private sense-data.

### MCQ 5

Quine's precise conclusion about the analytic/synthetic distinction is that:

A. there is no principled, non-circular criterion marking off a class of analytic truths B. no sentence has ever appeared analytic to any competent speaker C. every sentence is analytic D. analyticity is simply identical with logical truth

**Correct answer: A** - there is no principled, non-circular criterion marking off a class of analytic truths

**Explanation:** Quine denies a non-circular boundary, not the appearance of analyticity; logical truths are only one part of the alleged analytic class.

### MCQ 6

Interchangeability salva veritate fails to define synonymy because:

A. it is explicitly defined in terms of definition, which is circular B. in an extensional language it also links merely coextensive terms (e.g. "creature with a heart"/"creature with a kidney"), and restricting it with "necessarily" presupposes analyticity C. it cannot be expressed in any formal language D. it presupposes the indeterminacy of translation

**Correct answer: B** - in an extensional language it also links merely coextensive terms (e.g. "creature with a heart"/"creature with a kidney"), and restricting it with "necessarily" presupposes analyticity

**Explanation:** Extensional interchangeability over-generates; adding necessity to repair it reintroduces the very notion (analyticity) under analysis.

### MCQ 7

Quine regards the appeal to "semantic rules" in an artificial language as inadequate because such rules:

A. are internally self-contradictory B. cannot be written for any language C. merely stipulate which sentences are to count as analytic without explaining what analyticity is D. presuppose radical translation

**Correct answer: C** - merely stipulate which sentences are to count as analytic without explaining what analyticity is

**Explanation:** Listing analytic sentences by fiat specifies an extension, not the concept of analyticity.

#### MCQ 8

The Grice-Strawson reply "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) contends that:

A. Quine conclusively proved the distinction to be unreal B. synonymy can be straightforwardly defined by interchangeability C. analyticity is identical with empirical verifiability D. a distinction with agreed use and clear examples is not discredited merely by the absence of a reductive definition

**Correct answer: D** - a distinction with agreed use and clear examples is not discredited merely by the absence of a reductive definition

**Explanation:** They defend the distinction's reality via ordinary use; Quine replies this lacks the principled behavioural boundary logical empiricism required.

#### MCQ 9

The second dogma, reductionism, is the belief that:

A. each meaningful statement is equivalent to a logical construction upon terms referring to immediate experience, with its own range of confirming experiences B. all statements are analytic C. the meaning of a word is its use in the language D. reference is inscrutable

**Correct answer: A** - each meaningful statement is equivalent to a logical construction upon terms referring to immediate experience, with its own range of confirming experiences

**Explanation:** Radical reductionism is individual verificationism: each sentence is assigned its own private confirmation-conditions.

#### MCQ 10

In Quine's metaphor, the "web of belief" meets experience:

A. sentence by sentence, each independently B. only as a corporate body, and only at its edges / boundary conditions C. never, since experience is irrelevant to belief D. only through statements that are analytic

**Correct answer: B** - only as a corporate body, and only at its edges / boundary conditions

**Explanation:** Confirmation holism: the total field faces the tribunal of experience as a whole; only the periphery touches experience directly.

#### MCQ 11

"No statement is immune to revision" implies, for Quine, that:

A. the laws of logic are the one exception and cannot be revised B. only observation sentences are ever revisable C. even the laws of logic could in principle be revised to conserve the rest of the system D. only analytic truths are revisable

**Correct answer: C** - even the laws of logic could in principle be revised to conserve the rest of the system

**Explanation:** Holism extends revisability to logic itself, though logic is surrendered only under great pressure, by minimum mutilation.

#### MCQ 12

The contrast between "central" and "peripheral" statements in the web is one of:

A. truth versus falsity B. analytic versus synthetic, now vindicated in Quine's own theory C. meaningful versus meaningless D. degree of entrenchment / distance from experience, not a difference of kind

**Correct answer: D** - degree of entrenchment / distance from experience, not a difference of kind

**Explanation:** Centrality replaces the a priori/a posteriori split with a gradient of entrenchment, not a sharp boundary.

### MCQ 13

From  $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$  and an observed NOT-O, the Duhem-Quine point is that one may validly infer only:

A. NOT- $(H \ \& \ A)$  - something in the package is false, but logic does not say which conjunct B. NOT-H specifically C. NOT-A specifically D. that both H and A are confirmed

**Correct answer: A** - NOT- $(H \ \& \ A)$  - something in the package is false, but logic does not say which conjunct

**Explanation:** Modus tollens condemns the conjunction, leaving open which member to revise; that is why refutation is never decisive against one sentence.

### MCQ 14

How do Duhem's and Quine's versions of the thesis differ?

A. They are identical in scope and content B. Duhem restricts it to theoretical physics and exempts logic/mathematics, whereas Quine extends it to the whole of science, logic included C. Quine restricts it to physics while Duhem extends it to all knowledge D. Both explicitly exempt logic and mathematics

**Correct answer: B** - Duhem restricts it to theoretical physics and exempts logic/mathematics, whereas Quine extends it to the whole of science, logic included

**Explanation:** Scope is the key difference; Quine's extension to logic is the controversial step that drives the analytic/synthetic collapse.

### MCQ 15

The Neptune and Vulcan episodes together illustrate that:

A. revising an auxiliary is always the correct response to an anomaly B. revising the deep law is always the correct response C. the same logical situation can be correctly met by revising an auxiliary (Uranus  $\rightarrow$  Neptune) or by revising the deep law (Mercury  $\rightarrow$  general relativity), with no rule fixing which in advance D. Newtonian mechanics is in principle unrevisable

**Correct answer: C** - the same logical situation can be correctly met by revising an auxiliary (Uranus  $\rightarrow$  Neptune) or by revising the deep law (Mercury  $\rightarrow$  general relativity), with no rule fixing which in advance

**Explanation:** Neptune vindicated auxiliary revision; Vulcan failed and the correct fix was general relativity - opposite responses, identical logic.

### MCQ 16

Popper's response to the Duhem-Quine point is best described as:

A. a flat denial of the logical point B. an embrace of sceptical relativism about science C. a reduction of scientific method to individual psychology D. accepting the logic but treating falsification as a methodological decision that forbids ad hoc rescues

**Correct answer: D** - accepting the logic but treating falsification as a methodological decision that forbids ad hoc rescues

**Explanation:** Popper concedes the logic and adds methodological rules; Lakatos develops this into hard core / protective belt research programmes.

### MCQ 17

In the "Gavagai" scenario, why can the field linguist not settle whether the term means "rabbit" or "undetached rabbit-parts"?

A. Both translations fit the same stimulus meaning, and distinguishing them needs the native's apparatus of individuation (identity predicate, articles, plurals), which is itself undetermined B. The native speaker deliberately refuses to cooperate C. Rabbits move too quickly to be observed reliably D. The linguist lacks a bilingual dictionary

**Correct answer: A** - Both translations fit the same stimulus meaning, and distinguishing them needs the native's apparatus of individuation (identity predicate, articles, plurals), which is itself undetermined

**Explanation:** The rival translations share stimulus meaning; the "same gavagai?" question presupposes the very individuation apparatus under investigation.

### MCQ 18

"Inscrutability of reference" and "indeterminacy of translation" are related in that:

- A. they are simply two names for one identical claim
- B. inscrutability of reference (of terms) supports the broader indeterminacy of translation (of whole manuals of analytical hypotheses)
- C. they are logically opposed to each other
- D. both deny that stimulus meaning exists at all

**Correct answer: B** - inscrutability of reference (of terms) supports the broader indeterminacy of translation (of whole manuals of analytical hypotheses)

**Explanation:** Reference of sub-sentential terms is undetermined; rival analytical hypotheses generate whole manuals with no fact of the matter between them.

#### MCQ 19

Which premise does Quine himself acknowledge as driving the indeterminacy argument in the special case of language?

- A. rationalism about innate meanings
- B. Cartesian substance dualism
- C. behaviourism about the evidence for meaning - in linguistics, he says, "one has no choice"
- D. acceptance of the analytic/synthetic distinction

**Correct answer: C** - behaviourism about the evidence for meaning - in linguistics, he says, "one has no choice"

**Explanation:** The evidence for meaning is public verbal behaviour; the force of the argument tracks this behaviourist premise about evidence.

#### MCQ 20

Chomsky's objection to the indeterminacy of translation is that:

- A. meanings are Platonic abstract objects
- B. translation between languages is always fully determinate
- C. the notion of stimulus meaning is incoherent
- D. indeterminacy is merely the ordinary underdetermination of theory by evidence that also affects physics, so Quine owes a special argument for treating meaning worse than physical theory

**Correct answer: D** - indeterminacy is merely the ordinary underdetermination of theory by evidence that also affects physics, so Quine owes a special argument for treating meaning worse than physical theory

**Explanation:** Chomsky assimilates it to normal underdetermination; the burden falls on Quine to justify the asymmetry he posits between physics and meaning.

#### MCQ 21

Quine's criterion of ontological commitment is captured in the slogan:

- A. "To be is to be the value of a bound variable" (from "On What There Is", 1948)
- B. "To be is to be perceived"
- C. "The meaning of a word is its use"
- D. "Existence is a real predicate"

**Correct answer: A** - "To be is to be the value of a bound variable" (from "On What There Is", 1948)

**Explanation:** A theory is committed to the entities its bound variables must range over; note the slogan is from "On What There Is" (1948), not "Two Dogmas" (1951).

#### MCQ 22

"Naturalized epistemology" is Quine's proposal that:

- A. epistemology is really a branch of ethics
- B. epistemology becomes continuous with empirical science - in effect "a chapter of psychology" - abandoning the search for an a priori foundation
- C. knowledge is impossible and scepticism wins
- D. only a priori methods can yield genuine knowledge

**Correct answer: B** - epistemology becomes continuous with empirical science - in effect "a chapter of psychology" - abandoning the search for an a priori foundation

**Explanation:** From "Epistemology Naturalized" (1968/69): philosophy is continuous with science, not its prior tribunal; study how sensory input yields theory.

#### MCQ 23

"Ontological relativity" is the thesis that:

- A. every ontology whatsoever is equally false
- B. ontology is fixed absolutely by the laws of logic alone
- C. what a theory is "about" (the reference of its terms) is determinate only relative to a background language or translation

manual D. there are, strictly speaking, no objects at all

**Correct answer: C** - what a theory is "about" (the reference of its terms) is determinate only relative to a background language or translation manual

**Explanation:** Reference is relative to a background manual; "at home" we acquiesce in our mother tongue and take it at face value.

#### MCQ 24

The convergence between Quine and the later Wittgenstein is best stated as:

A. both defend the analytic/synthetic distinction B. both are epistemological foundationalists C. both accept private ostensive definition of sensations D. despite different methods, both reject determinate private meanings (the "museum myth"), Quine via indeterminacy and Wittgenstein via meaning-as-use

**Correct answer: D** - despite different methods, both reject determinate private meanings (the "museum myth"), Quine via indeterminacy and Wittgenstein via meaning-as-use

**Explanation:** They converge on anti-private-meaning holism, though Quine reforms language (regimentation) while Wittgenstein describes it ("in order as it is").

#### MCQ 25

For Strawson, a "basic particular" is one that:

A. can be identified without first identifying any other particular B. is metaphysically simple, indivisible and indestructible C. is a private sense-datum given in immediate experience D. exists of absolute necessity

**Correct answer: A** - can be identified without first identifying any other particular

**Explanation:** "Basic" is a claim of identification-independence (conceptual dependence), not of simplicity or necessity.

#### MCQ 26

Strawson's argument that material bodies are basic turns crucially on:

A. their causal powers to affect the senses B. the requirement that objective thought allow re-identification, which needs a single unified spatio-temporal system that material bodies constitute C. their being the objects most directly perceived D. their infinite divisibility

**Correct answer: B** - the requirement that objective thought allow re-identification, which needs a single unified spatio-temporal system that material bodies constitute

**Explanation:** Re-identification ("the same one again") requires one public space-time, and bodies are what compose that framework.

#### MCQ 27

The "no-space" (purely auditory) world thought experiment is designed to show that:

A. sounds are themselves the basic particulars B. objective experience of any kind is impossible C. re-identification without space is possible only by constructing a space-analogue, which concedes that a spatio-temporal framework is required D. space is merely a subjective illusion

**Correct answer: C** - re-identification without space is possible only by constructing a space-analogue, which concedes that a spatio-temporal framework is required

**Explanation:** The auditory world can support re-identification only by reintroducing a space-substitute (the "master-sound"), which supports Strawson's thesis.

#### MCQ 28

"Descriptive" as opposed to "revisionary" metaphysics is best defined as metaphysics that:

A. rejects metaphysics and conceptual analysis altogether B. constructs an ideal logical language to replace ordinary speech C. revises ordinary concepts to suit the needs of natural science D. lays bare the actual structure of our conceptual scheme rather than proposing a better one

**Correct answer: D** - lays bare the actual structure of our conceptual scheme rather than proposing a better one

**Explanation:** Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley are revisionary; Strawson (with Aristotle and Kant) is descriptive - Individuals (1959).

**MCQ 29**

To call the concept of a person "primitive" is to hold that it is:

A. not analysable into the concept of a pure ego plus that of a body, but logically prior to both  
B. vague, pre-scientific and destined to be replaced  
C. innate and present in the mind from birth  
D. identical with the concept of a living biological organism

**Correct answer: A** - not analysable into the concept of a pure ego plus that of a body, but logically prior to both

**Explanation:** Primitive = unanalysable into mind + body; those concepts are later abstractions from the person concept.

**MCQ 30**

P-predicates differ from M-predicates in that P-predicates are:

A. applicable only to inanimate material bodies  
B. ascribed to others on the basis of behavioural criteria but to oneself without observation  
C. always confined to weight and spatial location  
D. never ascribable to oneself at all

**Correct answer: B** - ascribed to others on the basis of behavioural criteria but to oneself without observation

**Explanation:** The asymmetry of ascription (others by behaviour, self without observation) is the defining mark of a P-predicate.

**MCQ 31**

The core premise of Strawson's argument for the primitiveness of the person is that:

A. the body causally produces the mind  
B. experiences are strictly unowned events  
C. self-ascription of P-predicates is possible only if one can also ascribe them to others  
D. only one's own mind can ever be known

**Correct answer: C** - self-ascription of P-predicates is possible only if one can also ascribe them to others

**Explanation:** Self-ascription requires other-ascription, which requires identifying others as single subjects of both M- and P-predicates.

**MCQ 32**

Strawson refutes the "no-ownership" theory by arguing that it:

A. contradicts the findings of empirical neuroscience  
B. is incompatible with substance dualism  
C. cannot be verified by observation  
D. cannot state the contingent dependence of experiences on a body without covertly using "my", thereby reintroducing the ownership it denies

**Correct answer: D** - cannot state the contingent dependence of experiences on a body without covertly using "my", thereby reintroducing the ownership it denies

**Explanation:** The theory is self-refuting: "my experiences" cannot be eliminated, so experiences are necessarily owned by a person.

**MCQ 33**

In "On Referring" (1950), Strawson's central objection to Russell is that Russell:

A. conflates the meaning of a sentence with the act of referring, treating the sentence itself as what refers  
B. denies that definite descriptions exist  
C. already accepts truth-value gaps  
D. rejects the use of formal logic altogether

**Correct answer: A** - conflates the meaning of a sentence with the act of referring, treating the sentence itself as what refers

**Explanation:** For Strawson people (not sentences) refer, in a use on an occasion; sentence meaning is a set of rules for such use.

**MCQ 34**

On Strawson's account, "The present King of France is bald" (there being no such king) is:

A. straightforwardly true  
B. neither true nor false, because a presupposition of the referring use fails  
C. false, because the sentence asserts a uniquely existing king and that fails  
D. literally meaningless



**Correct answer: B** - neither true nor false, because a presupposition of the referring use fails

**Explanation:** A failed presupposition yields a truth-value gap, not a falsehood - the sharp contrast with Russell.

#### MCQ 35

For Russell's Theory of Descriptions ("On Denoting", 1905), the same empty-subject sentence is:

- A. neither true nor false B. true by default C. false, because it asserts (and fails) that exactly one King of France exists  
D. a case of presupposition failure

**Correct answer: C** - false, because it asserts (and fails) that exactly one King of France exists

**Explanation:** Russell analyses "the" as a quantifier asserting unique existence; with no such king the whole statement is false.

#### MCQ 36

Strawson counts as a "critic of empiricism" (the syllabus phrase) chiefly because he argues that:

- A. empiricism is excessively mathematical B. sense-data are the only reality there is C. inductive inference is deductively valid  
D. identification of any particular presupposes a public spatio-temporal framework, so the private sense-datum cannot be the basic given

**Correct answer: D** - identification of any particular presupposes a public spatio-temporal framework, so the private sense-datum cannot be the basic given

**Explanation:** Strawson attacks empiricism's starting point (the private given), a critique at a different level from Quine's internal reform.

#### MCQ 37

The central disagreement between Quine and Strawson is best framed as whether the conceptual scheme is:

- A. holistically revisable "come what may" (Quine) or an indispensable precondition of objective thought (Strawson) B. true or false as a whole  
C. expressible in first-order logic D. compatible with the existence of God

**Correct answer: A** - holistically revisable "come what may" (Quine) or an indispensable precondition of objective thought (Strawson)

**Explanation:** Revisable web versus indispensable framework is the standing tension the examiner most often probes.

#### MCQ 38

Which of the following is a genuine convergence between Quine and Strawson?

- A. Both accept a robust analytic/synthetic distinction B. Both reject a private inner object as the anchor of meaning, making the public / holistic basic  
C. Both are revisionary metaphysicians building ideal languages D. Both deny that experience constrains belief in any way

**Correct answer: B** - Both reject a private inner object as the anchor of meaning, making the public / holistic basic

**Explanation:** Quine's behaviourism about meaning and Strawson's public criteria for P-predicates both reject the private given as the anchor of meaning.

#### MCQ 39

Treating Quine and Strawson as "basically agreeing" is a trap because they in fact differ on:

- A. nothing of philosophical importance B. matters of terminology only C. the status of the scheme (revisable vs precondition), the nature of meaning (indeterminate vs publicly fixed) and method (naturalist vs descriptive)  
D. whether persons exist at all

**Correct answer: C** - the status of the scheme (revisable vs precondition), the nature of meaning (indeterminate vs publicly fixed) and method (naturalist vs descriptive)

**Explanation:** Their convergence is in target and temper, not doctrine; the substantive differences remain sharp.

#### MCQ 40

The recommended "graded" closing position on the revisable-versus-indispensable question is that:



A. the scheme is wholly and uniformly revisable B. the scheme is wholly fixed and unrevisable C. the question itself is meaningless D. the periphery is Quineanly revisable, but some framework role (a public world, re-identifiable subjects) looks Strawsonianly indispensable - so the truth is layered

**Correct answer: D** - the periphery is Quineanly revisable, but some framework role (a public world, re-identifiable subjects) looks Strawsonianly indispensable - so the truth is layered

**Explanation:** A layered verdict captures what survives on each side rather than forcing an all-or-nothing choice.

#### Remedial MCQ 41

Which attribution observes correct provenance discipline?

A. "To be is to be the value of a bound variable" is from "On What There Is" (1948), not "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) B. The bound-variable slogan first appears in "Two Dogmas" (1951) C. Quantum logic was proposed jointly by Putnam and Birkhoff in 1936 D. Duhem himself extended the underdetermination thesis to all knowledge, including logic

**Correct answer: A** - "To be is to be the value of a bound variable" is from "On What There Is" (1948), not "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951)

**Explanation:** Provenance: the ontological-commitment slogan is 1948; quantum logic is Birkhoff & von Neumann (1936), pressed as empirical revision by Putnam (1968); Duhem restricted his thesis to physics.

#### Remedial MCQ 42

A common error states Quine's conclusion as "no sentence is really analytic." The accurate statement is that:

A. all sentences turn out to be synthetic B. there is no principled, non-circular criterion for analyticity, though familiar sentences may still appear analytic C. analytic sentences are all false D. analyticity just is necessity by definition

**Correct answer: B** - there is no principled, non-circular criterion for analyticity, though familiar sentences may still appear analytic

**Explanation:** Quine denies a principled boundary, not the appearance of analyticity; the over-strong reading loses marks.

#### Remedial MCQ 43

Davidson's "Radical Interpretation" (1973) is often confused with Quine's project. Correctly, it:

A. is identical to Quine's radical translation B. rejects indeterminacy of meaning entirely C. is interpretation (not translation) and treats residual indeterminacy as harmless, like a choice between Fahrenheit and Celsius D. denies that meaning is public at all

**Correct answer: C** - is interpretation (not translation) and treats residual indeterminacy as harmless, like a choice between Fahrenheit and Celsius

**Explanation:** Note the term "interpretation"; Davidson accepts indeterminacy but domesticates it to something like a choice of measurement scale.

#### Remedial MCQ 44

A frequent mistake is to call Strawson's descriptive metaphysics "anti-metaphysical." Correctly, it:

A. rejects all conceptual analysis B. constructs an ideal logical language C. denies that persons exist D. is itself metaphysics - it describes the actual structure of our conceptual scheme instead of revising it

**Correct answer: D** - is itself metaphysics - it describes the actual structure of our conceptual scheme instead of revising it

**Explanation:** Descriptive versus revisionary is a contrast within metaphysics, not a rejection of it.

#### Remedial MCQ 45

"In Defence of a Dogma" (1956), which defends the analytic/synthetic distinction against Quine, was written by:

A. H. P. Grice and P. F. Strawson B. Strawson alone C. Quine and Carnap D. Russell and Strawson

**Correct answer: A** - H. P. Grice and P. F. Strawson

**Explanation:** The paper is co-authored by Grice and Strawson; do not attribute it to Strawson alone.

### Remedial MCQ 46

Strawson's use of behavioural criteria for P-predicates commits him to the view that:

A. P-predicates simply mean patterns of behaviour (logical behaviourism) B. behaviour is criterial evidence for P-predicates, not their meaning C. the mental should be eliminated from the account D. Cartesian dualism is correct after all

**Correct answer: B** - behaviour is criterial evidence for P-predicates, not their meaning

**Explanation:** Strawson insists P-predicates are not reducible to behaviour; behaviour is criterial, not definitional - so he is not a logical behaviourist.

### Remedial MCQ 47

On the empty-subject sentence, the Russell/Strawson split is correctly stated as:

A. both hold it is neither true nor false B. both hold it is false C. Russell holds it is false (unique existence asserted and fails); Strawson holds it is neither true nor false (a presupposition fails) D. Russell holds it is true; Strawson holds it is false

**Correct answer: C** - Russell holds it is false (unique existence asserted and fails); Strawson holds it is neither true nor false (a presupposition fails)

**Explanation:** The verdicts diverge precisely on falsity (Russell) versus a truth-value gap (Strawson).

### Remedial MCQ 48

Which question should NOT be counted as owned by "Quine and Strawson", despite conceptual overlap?

A. a question on Strawson's theory of persons B. a question on Quine's web of belief and holism C. a question on Strawson's basic particulars D. a question owned primarily by Kant on the defence of the synthetic a priori

**Correct answer: D** - a question owned primarily by Kant on the defence of the synthetic a priori

**Explanation:** Ownership discipline keeps Logical Positivism, Empiricism and Kant questions separate even where they overlap Quine's critique of empiricism.

## PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

### EXAM APPLICATION 1 - Two-Project Map - One Syllabus Heading, Two Philosophers, Two Different Critiques of Empiricism

#### How the map frames every answer

- **Universal opener.** For any part on this item, one sentence orients the examiner: "The syllabus pairs two critics of empiricism who criticise it differently - Quine reforms its epistemology from within (holism), while Strawson rejects its sense-data starting point (basic particulars and persons)." Then narrow to the exact demand.
- **Ownership facts that must be right:** this clause owns **9** Western Philosophy PYQ parts across 2018-2025, with **none in 2022** (two each in 2018 and 2021). Roughly five parts are Quine-side (analytic/synthetic, two dogmas, holism, a-priori-as-faith) and four are Strawson-side (person, basic particulars, spatio-temporal thinking, person as primitive). Keep questions primarily owned by **Logical Positivism**, **Empiricism** and **Kant** separate even where they overlap.
- **Routing rule:** if the stem names "dogmas", "analytic-synthetic", "web of belief" or "a priori as a metaphysical article of faith", it is a **Quine** answer; if it names "person", "basic particulars" or "spatio-temporal thinking", it is a **Strawson** answer. Only a "critique of empiricism - discuss" stem obliges *both* names.

**10-mark use:** one orienting sentence, then straight to the demand. **15/20-mark use:** the map as a compact frame, the targeted project developed in depth, closing on how the part illuminates the shared anti-empiricist aim.

## EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Quine, Dogma 1 - The Analytic/Synthetic Distinction and the Circle of Synonymy

### Verified routes and answer architecture (this subtopic anchors the 2019 part)

- **2019 Q1(e), 10 marks** - "Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction." Spine: state the positivist division -> run the circle (meaning -> synonymy -> definition / interchangeability *salva veritate* / semantic rules, each circular) -> conclusion: difference of degree, not kind -> one line of Grice-Strawson reply and Quine's rejoinder.
- **Feeds the 2024 Q4(c) 15m** ("nature of the two dogmas") and the 2021 Q3(c) 15m ("empiricism without the dogmas") - Dogma 1 is half of each (subtopic 3 supplies Dogma 2 and holism).
- **Directive care:** "explain" wants the *chain*, not a verdict-heavy essay; still close with the degree-not-kind result. "Examine/critically discuss" adds the Grice-Strawson exchange and a ruling.
- **10-mark architecture:**

State : positivists split analytic (true by meaning) vs synthetic (true by fact).

Quine : "analytic" -> synonymy -> definition (records synonymy, CIRCULAR)  
or interchangeability *salva veritate* (needs necessity = analyticity, CIRCULAR)  
or semantic rules (defined via "analytic-in-L", CIRCULAR).

Result : the distinction is a dogma - a difference of degree (centrality), not kind.

Assess : Grice-Strawson - we can sort cases pre-theoretically;  
Quine - usability is not a principled foundation.

## EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Quine, Dogma 2 and the Positive Doctrine - Reductionism Rejected, Confirmation Holism and the Web of Belief

### Verified routes and answer architecture (this subtopic owns the 2025 quotation part)

- **2025 Q4(b), 15 marks** - "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system ... just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." Spine: place it as section 6 of "Two Dogmas" (holism after both dogmas fall) -> corporate body + web/field-of-force -> the conditional clause is the doctrine (Duhem-Quine underwrites it, subtopic 4) -> "no statement is immune" -> consequences (no analytic/synthetic or a priori/a posteriori line; pragmatic theory-choice) -> assess: not relativism; minimum mutilation; verdict.
- **2024 Q4(c), 15 marks** - "nature of the two dogmas" - Dogma 2 half is here (reductionism), Dogma 1 half from subtopic 2.
- **2021 Q3(c), 15 marks** - "empiricism without the dogmas" - both dogmas fall, holism is the positive residue; note the title phrase is the sixth section's heading.
- **Directive care:** "Discuss this statement" (2025) demands you *decode the quotation*, not summarise the paper - foreground the conditional clause and the pragmatic constraint.
- **15-mark architecture:**

Frame : "Two Dogmas" section 6 - holism as the positive replacement.

Expo : corporate body; web / field of force; conflict at edge -> choice of revision;  
"come what may" (adjust elsewhere); "no statement immune" (not even logic).

Conseq : no analytic/synthetic or a priori/a posteriori line; theory-choice pragmatic.

Assess : not "anything goes" (minimum mutilation); if logic revisable, what constrains?

Close : holism frees empiricism from atomism - the web is a truer model than the bucket.

## EXAM APPLICATION 4 - The Duhem-Quine Thesis - Why No Single Hypothesis Faces Experience Alone

### Verified routes and answer architecture (the engine behind two owned parts)

- **Underwrites 2025 Q4(b), 15 marks** ("any sentence ... adjustments elsewhere") - the quotation is *true because of* the test chain; decode it with modus tollens on (H & A) -> O, then the Neptune/Vulcan pair.
- **Underwrites 2021 Q3(c), 15 marks** ("empiricism without the dogmas") - holism is the positive residue, and Duhem-Quine is why individual confirmation is impossible.
- **Not itself a stand-alone PYQ owner** - but a 15/20-mark answer on holism that omits the Duhem-Quine machinery is thin; a 10-marker can invoke it in one sentence.
- **Directive care:** if asked to "comment on the quotation", foreground the *conditional clause* and the structural (not sceptical) nature of the point; add Popper/Lakatos only in 15/20-mark answers.

- **15-mark insert:**

Claim : no hypothesis faces experience alone; (H & A) → 0.  
Logic : not-0 ⇒ not-(H & A); logic does not say which conjunct.  
Split : Duhem - physics only, logic exempt, no crucial experiment (1906);  
Quine - whole of science, logic included, underdetermination (1951).  
Example: Uranus → revise auxiliary → Neptune (1846);  
Mercury → "Vulcan" fails → revise deep law → relativity (1915).  
Reply : Popper (methodological decision) and Lakatos (hard core / protective belt).

## EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Radical Translation and 'Gavagai' - Inscrutability of Reference and Indeterminacy of Translation

### Verified routes and answer architecture (enrichment that lifts the Quine 15/20s)

- **Not a stand-alone PYQ owner**, but the constructive completion of the analytic/synthetic critique - deploy it to deepen any 15/20-mark answer on Quine's attack on meaning (2019 Q1(e), 2024 Q4(c), 2021 Q3(c)): "the circle shows analyticity cannot be defined; gavagai shows why - there are no determinate meanings for a definition to capture."
- **Directive care:** "assess indeterminacy of translation" (a probable future stem) demands the gavagai construction, then the behaviourist premise, then Chomsky and a ruling. "Explain" wants the numbered construction and the two results (inscrutability, indeterminacy).
- **20-mark insert:**

Set-up : radical translation; only evidence = stimulus + assent/dissent.  
Case : "Gavagai" = rabbit / undetached rabbit-parts / rabbit-stage / rabbithood /  
"it is rabbiting" - all share one stimulus meaning.  
Move : asking "same gavagai?" presupposes the identity apparatus (in dispute).  
Result : inscrutability of reference → indeterminacy of translation →  
no determinate meanings → ontological relativity.  
Premise: behaviourism about evidence + verificationism about facts + naturalism.  
Assess : Chomsky's underdetermination objection; Davidson's harmless version; rule.

## EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Ontological Commitment, Naturalized Epistemology and Ontological Relativity - and Quine's Convergence with the Later Wittgenstein

### Verified routes and answer architecture (the naturalist home of the 2018 a-priori part)

- **2018 Q2(c), 15 marks** - "How does Quine show that a priori knowledge (Kant's) is 'a metaphysical article of faith'?"  
The full mechanics live in the analytic/synthetic circle (subtopic 2) and holism erasing the a priori/a posteriori line (subtopic 3); *this* subtopic supplies the naturalist frame - there is no first-philosophy standpoint from which to certify a priori knowledge, so treating it as underived is an unfounded article of faith. (Keep the Kant topic's own defence of the synthetic a priori separate.)
- **Enriches every Quine 15/20** - ontological commitment and naturalism show Quine's *positive* system, so an answer on "empiricism without the dogmas" (2021 Q3(c)) can close on the constructive residue, not just the demolition.
- **Directive care:** the 2018 stem's key phrase is Quine's charge; do not merely expound Kant. Show *why* the a priori becomes "faith": no principled analytic/synthetic line + holistic revisability + naturalism.
- **15-mark insert:**

Frame : Kant's a priori needs a principled a priori/a posteriori boundary.  
Quine : (i) the analytic/synthetic circle denies a non-circular criterion;  
(ii) holism makes all belief revisable - even logic - so no belief is  
a priori by nature, only central by degree;  
(iii) naturalism denies any first-philosophy tribunal to certify the a priori.  
Charge: to hold the a priori is then a "metaphysical article of faith" - unfounded.  
Assess: gradients of entrenchment, not a sharp a priori boundary; Kant can reply  
that transcendental conditions are not empirical hypotheses - rule on it.

## EXAM APPLICATION 7 - Strawson's Basic Particulars - Material Bodies and the Single Spatio-Temporal Framework

### Verified routes and answer architecture (home of two owned 15-markers)

- **2020 Q3(b), 15 marks** - "Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars." Spine: objectivity needs the seems/is distinction -> that needs re-identifiable particulars -> that needs one public spatio-temporal system -> bodies constitute it -> hence spatio-temporal thinking is a precondition of *objective* thought (Kantian resonance); then evaluate with the auditory-world test and one objection.
- **2021 Q3(b), 15 marks** - "What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss." Spine: define basic (identification-independence) -> bodies via re-identification -> **persons as the second basic particular** (bridge to subtopic 8) -> critical discussion (no-space objection; whether persons are really co-basic).
- **Directive care:** "evaluate" / "critically discuss" require the objection and a verdict, not just exposition; "with reference to ..." obliges you to route the general point through Strawson's own apparatus.
- **15-mark insert:**

Frame : descriptive (not revisionary) metaphysics - describe our actual scheme.  
Def : basic particular = identifiable without identifying anything else.  
Arg : objective thought needs re-identification -> needs one spatio-temporal system -> material bodies constitute it -> bodies are basic.  
Second : persons are the other basic particular (subtopic 8).  
Test : the no-space (auditory) world - re-identification needs a space-analogue.  
Assess : Evans-type objection; verdict - the dependence claim survives.

## EXAM APPLICATION 8 - Strawson's Persons - The Primitive Concept, M/P-Predicates, and the Block on Dualism

### Verified routes and answer architecture (home of the 10-marker and the 20-marker)

- **2018 Q1(e), 10 marks** - "How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss." Compact spine: person = primitive concept -> M/P-predicates on one subject -> self-ascription requires other-ascription -> blocks dualism. Four crisp moves, one line each, plus a closing verdict.
- **2023 Q4(a), 20 marks** - "Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss." The canonical 20-mark architecture: (1) define primitive; (2) the predicate matrix; (3) the full self-ascription argument; (4) the block on dualism *and* the no-ownership theory; (5) objections (co-instantiation, Ayer, behaviourism worry) and a graded verdict. This is the single most reused Strawson answer - master its skeleton.
- **Also the second half of 2021 Q3(b)** - persons as the co-basic particular alongside material bodies (bridge from subtopic 7).
- **Directive care:** "why ... primitive" demands the *argument for primitiveness* (not just the assertion); "implication for dualism" demands you *derive* the anti-Cartesian conclusion, and the strongest answers add the no-ownership half.
- **20-mark insert:**

Define : person = logically primitive; NOT mind + body assembled.  
Matrix : M-predicates (also of bodies) + P-predicates (only of persons; asymmetric - others by behaviour, self without observation).  
Argue : self-ascription of P-predicates presupposes other-ascription -> presupposes identifying others as single M-and-P subjects -> person concept is primitive.  
Dualism: two substances cannot be the single subject; other minds become unknowable; P-ascription unintelligible -> dualism fails.  
Also : no-ownership theory self-refutes ("my" cannot be eliminated).  
Assess : co-instantiation objection; Ayer; not logical behaviourism - verdict.

## EXAM APPLICATION 9 - 'On Referring' versus Russell, and Strawson as a Critic of Empiricism

### Verified routes and answer architecture (enrichment that raises every Strawson answer)

- **No stand-alone PYQ owns "On Referring"** in the 2018-2025 corpus, but it is high-value enrichment: it supplies the meaning/use distinction and the presupposition apparatus, and it is the cleanest evidence for the syllabus phrase "critique of empiricism" *as applied to Strawson*. Deploy it to deepen 2020 Q3(b) and 2021 Q3(b) (the public-framework point) and to answer any future stem on Strawson and Russell or on reference.
- **The critic-of-empiricism angle** is the natural high-level frame for *any* Strawson answer: state that Strawson, like Quine, is a critic of empiricism, but at the level of its starting point (the private given) rather than its dogmas (analyticity, reductionism).
- **Directive care:** if a future stem asks "compare Russell and Strawson on referring", the table is your spine - who refers, logical form, the empty-subject verdict, meaning vs use - then a verdict that maps the dispute onto description vs regimentation.
- **15-mark insert:**

Frame : sentences do not refer; people do, in a use on an occasion (Strawson 1950).  
Russell: "the K of F is bald" = "exactly one K and it is bald" -> FALSE (1905).  
Straw. : "the" presupposes (not asserts) existence -> failure = truth-value GAP.  
Levels : sentence (meaning = rules) / use (truth-value arises) / utterance.  
Reply : Russell serves formal logic; Strawson describes usage - aim differs.  
Bridge : same anti-atomism as the metaphysics -> Strawson as critic of empiricism  
(the public given vs the private sense-datum).

## EXAM APPLICATION 10 - Synthesis - Quine versus Strawson, Their Convergences, and the Universal Answer Spine

### Verified routes and answer architecture (the spine behind all nine PYQs)

- **No stand-alone PYQ owns the comparison**, but the confrontation is the *frame* that lifts every answer from exposition to argument, and the answer spine below is reusable for all nine owned parts.
- **Use the convergences as your high-value close** on any 15/20-marker: after stating the owner-thinker's doctrine, note the anti-Cartesian / public-anchor / anti-museum convergence to show breadth, then resolve on the revisable-vs-indispensable pivot.
- **Ownership reminder for comparative stems:** do not import Logical Positivism, Empiricism or Kant material as if it were owned here; cite it as background only.
- **Universal answer spine (all marks):**

1 DECODE : parse the directive; name the owner-thinker (Quine or Strawson).  
2 THESIS : one-line claim (e.g. "the analytic/synthetic line cannot be drawn").  
3 MECH : the exact mechanism + term (circle / web / Duhem-Quine / gavagai / basic particulars / predicate matrix / presupposition).  
4 OBJ->REP: strongest objection, named (Grice-Strawson / Chomsky / Evans / Ayer), then the reply.  
5 VERDICT : graded position (what survives, what fails) + provenance-clean date.

- **Mark-tier tailoring:** 10 marks = spine steps 1-3 + a one-line verdict; 15 marks = full spine + one objection; 20 marks = full spine + two objections + convergence close.

### Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 9 owner questions, with none in 2022 (two each in 2018 and 2021).
- Ownership discipline: questions primarily owned by Logical Positivism, Empiricism or Kant are kept separate even where they overlap conceptually with Quine's critique of empiricism; the two projects (Quine's critique of empiricism; Strawson's basic particulars and persons) are kept distinct.
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: thesis -> named source / argument -> analysis -> objection/reply -> verdict, each closing with a "Why this earns marks" note.
- MCQs: 40 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 48, strict A-B-C-D rotation twelve times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.



- Provenance discipline observed throughout (Two Dogmas 1951; On What There Is 1948; Word and Object 1960; Individuals 1959; On Referring 1950; In Defence of a Dogma - Grice and Strawson - 1956; Duhem 1906; quantum logic Birkhoff and von Neumann 1936, Putnam 1968).
- No current-affairs anchor is used (no verified development found 2026-02-19 to 2026-08-19); relevance is static and syllabus-driven.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

## Practice Design

The workbook sequence is the nine exact verified PYQs -> 40 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus block in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED SOURCE / EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION / REPLY -> VERDICT

## SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 9 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. Quine and Strawson own exactly 9 primary parts, with none in 2022 (two each in 2018 and 2021). Ownership discipline: questions primarily owned by Logical Positivism, Empiricism or Kant are kept strictly separate even where they overlap conceptually with Quine's critique of empiricism.

### Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q1(e), 10 marks

**Question:** How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss.

**Source metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](https://upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md).

#### Model solution

**Thesis.** Strawson explains the person not as a compound of mind and body but as a **logically primitive concept** - the concept of a single subject to which we ascribe both bodily and mental predicates, and which is presupposed by, rather than assembled from, the concepts of a pure ego and a pure body (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3).

**The predicate matrix.** A person is that to which we ascribe both **M-predicates** - properties we also ascribe to mere material bodies ("weighs 70 kg", "is in the corner") - and **P-predicates** - states of consciousness and action ascribable only to persons ("is in pain", "believes that p", "is going for a walk"). The mark of a P-predicate is its **asymmetry**: it is ascribed to others on the basis of observed behaviour, but to oneself without observation or criteria.

**The argument (self-ascription requires other-ascription).** I can ascribe P-predicates to myself only if the same predicates are ascribable to others; to ascribe them to others I must identify others as single subjects of both M- and P-predicates. Hence the concept of such a subject - a person - is presupposed by the very possibility of self-ascription, and is therefore primitive.

**Consequence.** This blocks Cartesian dualism (two independent substances could not be the single subject our predicate-practice requires, and other minds would become unknowable) and the no-ownership theory (which cannot state its own claim without covertly reintroducing ownership).

**Verdict.** The person concept is the indispensable middle term between mind and body; treating either as prior mislocates the foundation.

**Why this earns marks:** it names the exact apparatus (primitive concept, M/P-predicates, self-ascription requiring other-ascription), draws the anti-Cartesian consequence, and dates the source - four disciplined moves that fill a 10-marker without padding.

### Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q2(c), 15 marks

**Question:** How does Quine show that the notion of a priori knowledge as discussed by Kant is 'a metaphysical article of faith'? Give reasons for your answer.

**Source metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](https://upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md).



## Model solution

**Thesis.** Quine's charge that Kant's *a priori* is "a metaphysical article of faith" is the conclusion of three connected moves: there is no principled analytic/synthetic boundary; confirmation is holistic, so no statement is *a priori by nature*; and naturalism denies any first-philosophy standpoint from which the *a priori* could be certified. Kant's *a priori* therefore rests on an undischarged assumption - an article of faith.

**Move 1 - the analytic/synthetic circle.** Kant's synthetic *a priori* presupposes a clear analytic/synthetic distinction. In "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951) Quine shows analyticity can be explained only through synonymy, definition, interchangeability *salva veritate*, necessity and semantic rules - each of which presupposes analyticity. The boundary cannot be drawn non-circularly, so the category on which Kant's *a priori* depends is unfounded.

**Move 2 - holism.** Because beliefs "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body" (the web of belief), *any* statement can be held true come what may, and none is immune to revision - even logic. So no belief is *a priori in its nature*; apparent apriority is only greater centrality in the web, a matter of degree, not of kind.

**Move 3 - naturalism.** Philosophy is continuous with science, not its *a priori* tribunal; there is no external vantage from which to guarantee *a priori* knowledge. To assert it is therefore to take on trust exactly what cannot be shown - "a metaphysical article of faith".

**Objection and reply.** Kant can respond that transcendental conditions of experience are not empirical hypotheses inside the web, so holistic revisability does not touch them (Strawson's descriptive-metaphysics reading protects a framework role). Quine's rejoinder: that reply reasserts a privileged non-empirical status which is precisely the article of faith in question.

**Verdict.** Quine succeeds against a *sharp* *a priori/a posteriori* boundary; what survives is a gradient of entrenchment, not a certified Kantian *a priori* - though whether *some* framework role escapes the web is the live residue (kept separate from the Kant paper's own defence).

**Why this earns marks:** it keeps the question Quine's (not a Kant exposition), runs all three mechanisms with exact terms and the 1951 dating, and closes on a graded verdict.

### Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q1(e), 10 marks

**Question:** Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction.

**Source metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](https://upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md).

## Model solution

**Thesis.** Quine argues that the analytic/synthetic distinction cannot be drawn by any principled, **non-circular** criterion; every proposed explanation of "analytic" presupposes a notion from the same family. His conclusion is precise: not that no sentence *seems* analytic, but that there is no principled boundary marking a class of truths true *by meaning alone*.

**The circle of meaning (reproduce it).** (1) Analytic truths divide into logical truths and those reducible to logical truths by substituting **synonyms**; so analyticity needs **synonymy**. (2) Synonymy might be explained by **definition** - but a good definition *reports* an antecedent synonymy, so this is circular. (3) Or by **interchangeability salva veritate** - *but in an extensional language this over-generates (coextensive terms like "creature with a heart"/"creature with a kidney" interchange without being synonymous), and adding "necessarily" to fix it presupposes necessity, which for Quine is intelligible only via analyticity*. (4) Or by **semantic rules in an artificial language** - *but these merely list what is to count as analytic, without saying what analyticity is*\*. Every road returns to the start.

**Analysis.** The dogma survives only as an unexplained primitive; the appearance of analyticity is really only greater centrality in the web of belief - a difference of degree, not of kind.

**Objection and reply.** Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) argue that a distinction in ordinary use with agreed examples is not discredited merely because no reductive definition is available. Quine's reply: agreed examples do not supply the *principled behavioural boundary* the epistemology of logical empiricism required.

**Verdict.** Quine wins where the distinction was load-bearing (the verification principle, the linguistic theory of necessity); the exact result is the failure of a non-circular criterion, not the denial that "bachelors are unmarried" looks

analytic.

**Why this earns marks:** it gives the closed circle step by step, states the precise (often-missed) conclusion, and answers the standard Grice-Strawson objection.

#### Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 Q3(b), 15 marks

**Question:** Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars.

**Source metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](#).

#### Model solution

**Thesis.** For Strawson, **spatio-temporal thinking is a precondition of objective thinking itself**: we can think of a world of particulars that exist independently of our experience only because we can locate and re-locate them in a single public spatio-temporal framework - and material bodies, his basic particulars, are what constitute that framework (*Individuals*, 1959).

**Objectivity and re-identification.** Objective thought requires the distinction between "how things are" and "how they seem to me". That distinction has a use only if I can **re-identify** particulars - judge "this is the same one I encountered before" - across gaps in observation. Re-identification in turn requires a **single, unified system of space and time** within which a thing traces a continuous career.

**Why material bodies are basic.** Bodies are three-dimensional, relatively enduring and publicly located; they compose the one spatio-temporal system, and every more shadowy particular (a sound, a flash, a private sensation) is identified only by reference to bodies and their positions. So bodies are the **basic particulars** - identifiable without first identifying anything else - and spatio-temporal thinking is built into objective thought.

**The no-space test.** Strawson's purely **auditory world** asks whether a non-spatial being could sustain re-identification. His answer: only by constructing a sound-analogue of space (a "master-sound" whose pitch fixes position) - which *concedes* the thesis, since a space-substitute must be reintroduced.

**Objection and reply.** Evans and others argue the auditory construction may smuggle in spatial notions or fall short of genuine re-identification, and that a merely temporal framework might suffice. Reply: even the minimal construction must reintroduce something that plays space's *individuating* role, which is the substantive claim.

**Verdict.** Spatio-temporal thinking is not a convenient tool for finding things but a **transcendental condition** of there being objective particulars to think about; the dependence claim survives the objections.

**Why this earns marks:** it routes the general "objectivity" point through Strawson's own re-identification argument and auditory-world test, and evaluates rather than merely expounds.

#### Solved PYQ 5 - 2021 Q3(b), 15 marks

**Question:** What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss.

**Source metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](#).

#### Model solution

**Thesis.** Basic particulars are the particulars that can be **identified without first identifying anything else**; Strawson argues that **material bodies** and **persons** are the two basic categories, because both are required for the single public framework in which objective particular-identification is possible (*Individuals*, 1959).

**Material bodies.** Objective thought requires **re-identification** of particulars, which requires a **single, unified spatio-temporal system**; material bodies - three-dimensional, enduring, publicly located - constitute that system, and every other particular (events, processes, private experiences) is identified by reference to them. Hence bodies are basic. The **no-space (auditory) world** confirms this: re-identification without space is possible only by building a space-analogue.

**Persons.** Persons are the *second* basic particular because the concept of a person is **primitive** - a single subject of both **M-predicates** (also true of bodies) and **P-predicates** (states of consciousness, ascribed to others on behavioural

criteria, to oneself without observation). Since **self-ascription of P-predicates requires other-ascription**, and other-ascription requires identifying others as embodied subjects, persons cannot be reduced to bodies-plus-egos; they are irreducibly basic.

**Critical discussion.** (i) Are persons genuinely *co-basic* with bodies, or dependent on them (since persons are a kind of body)? Strawson's answer: persons are not *reducible* to bodies because P-predicates cannot be analysed in purely bodily terms, so both categories are needed. (ii) Evans-type objections to the auditory world; (iii) whether the argument establishes *primitiveness* or only *co-instantiation* of the mental and bodily.

**Verdict.** The dual thesis holds: bodies ground the spatio-temporal framework, persons ground the subject of experience, and neither category can be dissolved into the other without losing the conditions of objective thought.

**Why this earns marks:** it defines "basic" precisely, argues bodies *and* persons with their distinct mechanisms (re-identification; primitiveness), and delivers the "critically discuss" demand with real objections.

### Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q3(c), 15 marks

**Question:** Critically examine Quine's postulate of empiricism without the dogmas with reference to his 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

**Source metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](https://upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md).

#### Model solution

**Thesis.** "Empiricism without the dogmas" is Quine's positive doctrine: once the two dogmas are abandoned, what remains is a **holistic empiricism** in which experience still governs belief, but the whole web of belief - not the individual sentence - faces the tribunal of experience (*Two Dogmas of Empiricism*, 1951).

**The two dogmas removed.** Dogma 1, the **analytic/synthetic distinction**, fails because "analytic" has no non-circular criterion (synonymy, definition, interchangeability *salva veritate*, necessity, semantic rules all presuppose it). Dogma 2, **reductionism** - the belief that each meaningful statement is equivalent to a construction upon terms referring to immediate experience, so that each has its own range of confirming experiences - fails because no statement is confirmed in isolation.

**The positive residue - holism.** Our beliefs form a **web** or "field of force" that impinges on experience only at its edges; a recalcitrant experience forces readjustment *somewhere*, but which statements to revise is **underdetermined** by experience, so "no statement is immune to revision" and "any statement can be held true come what may". This is the **Duhem-Quine** point: a hypothesis meets experience only conjoined with auxiliaries. Empiricism survives as the thesis that experience is the only check on belief; what is dropped is the atomistic idea that it checks sentences one by one.

**Objection and reply.** (i) Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) argue Quine has not shown the analytic/synthetic distinction is *unreal*, only undefined - so the residue may be an overreach. (ii) If any statement can be saved, does holism license irrationalism? Reply: revision is disciplined by pragmatic virtues - **minimum mutilation**, conservatism, simplicity - so holism is not "anything goes". (iii) Quine himself concedes we may keep speaking of centrality and periphery, which does much of the analytic/synthetic work by degree.

**Verdict.** The postulate is coherent and powerful: empiricism is *reformed*, not abandoned - experience governs the corporate body of belief holistically - but its cost is the loss of any sharp a priori/empirical line, replaced by gradients of entrenchment.

**Why this earns marks:** it explains *both* dogmas, isolates the exact positive residue (holism + pragmatic constraints), and critically examines it with the standard objections and a ruling.

### Solved PYQ 7 - 2023 Q4(a), 20 marks

**Question:** Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss.

**Source metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](https://upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md).

#### Model solution

**Thesis.** Strawson considers **person** a *primitive* concept because it cannot be analysed as a composite of a pure Cartesian ego and a material body; rather, the concept of a single subject bearing both bodily and mental predicates is **logically prior** to, and presupposed by, both. Its chief implication is the collapse of mind-body dualism, since two independent substances could not be the one subject our predicate-practice demands (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3, "Persons").

**1. What "primitive" means.** To call the person concept primitive is to deny that it is *definable* in terms of the concept of a pure consciousness plus the concept of a body. Those two concepts are, for Strawson, *later abstractions* from the person concept, not its constituents; the Cartesian order of analysis is inverted.

**2. The predicate matrix.** We ascribe to one and the same individual both **M-predicates** (also true of mere bodies - "weighs 70 kg", "is in the room") and **P-predicates** (states of consciousness and action - "is in pain", "believes", "is going for a walk"). P-predicates are **asymmetric**: ascribed to others on behavioural criteria, to oneself without observation. That a single concept carries predicates of this double character is the central datum.

**3. The self-ascription argument.** (i) I ascribe P-predicates to myself. (ii) A predicate I ascribe to myself must be one I can ascribe to others. (iii) To ascribe P-predicates to others I must identify them as single subjects of both M- and P-predicates. (iv) Therefore the concept of such a subject - a person - is presupposed by self-ascription itself; it is primitive.

**4. Implication for dualism.** On dualism the real subject is an immaterial ego and the body a separate substance. Then P-predicates would attach to an ego I can never observe in others, so I could neither learn nor apply them - and so could not self-ascribe them either; and two logically independent substances could not be the *single* subject our practice requires. Dualism makes other minds unknowable and P-ascription unintelligible. **The mirror error - the no-ownership theory** (Lichtenberg's "it thinks" for Descartes's "I think") - is equally blocked: it cannot state that experiences depend on *this* body rather than that without covertly using "my", reintroducing the ownership it denies. So experiences are necessarily owned by a person.

**5. Objections and reply.** (i) Does the argument prove *primitiveness*, or only that the mental and bodily are *co-instantiated*? Strawson: mere co-instantiation would not explain the asymmetric logic of P-predicates, which requires a single subject-concept. (ii) Ayer defended a version of the no-ownership view; Strawson's self-reference point answers it. (iii) The behavioural-criteria premise risks logical behaviourism; Strawson insists behaviour is *critical evidence*, not the *meaning* of P-predicates.

**Verdict.** The person is the indispensable middle term between mind and body; dualism and no-ownership both fail because each denies the single subject that the logic of P-predicates presupposes. What survives even under the co-instantiation worry is that any adequate scheme must treat the person, not the ego or the body, as basic.

**Why this earns marks:** it delivers the full 20-mark architecture - define primitive, matrix, self-ascription argument, the block on *both* dualism and no-ownership, then named objections and a graded verdict - with the 1959 source.

### Solved PYQ 8 - 2024 Q4(c), 15 marks

**Question:** Explain the nature of the two dogmas that Quine refers to in his paper 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

**Source metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](https://upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md).

### Model solution

**Thesis.** The two dogmas Quine attacks in "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951) are (1) the belief in a fundamental **analytic/synthetic distinction**, and (2) **reductionism** - the belief that every meaningful statement is equivalent to some logical construction upon terms referring to immediate experience. Quine argues both are ill-founded and that they are "at root identical".

**Dogma 1 - the analytic/synthetic distinction.** The claim is that some truths are true *by meaning* (analytic) and others *by fact* (synthetic). Quine shows "analytic" can be explained only through a circle of interdefinable notions - **synonymy, definition, interchangeability salva veritate, necessity, semantic rules** - each presupposing analyticity. No non-circular criterion exists, so the distinction lacks the principled basis empiricism claimed for it. His precise conclusion is the absence of a boundary, not the denial that some sentences seem analytic.

**Dogma 2 - reductionism.** In its radical form (Locke, Hume, early Carnap's *Aufbau*) each statement has its *own* unique range of confirming or infirming experiences - **verificationism at the level of the individual sentence**. Quine

argues no statement is confirmed in isolation: statements meet experience only in concert (the **Duhem-Quine** point), so the idea of statement-by-statement verification collapses.

**Why the two dogmas are "at root identical".** The analytic/synthetic distinction and reductionism are two sides of one verificationist theory of meaning: an analytic statement is the limiting case of one confirmed "come what may" (empty confirmation-conditions), while reductionism assigns each synthetic statement its private confirmation-conditions. Reject individual verification and both the sharp analytic pole and the reductionist picture fall together.

**Consequence - holism.** What replaces them is **confirmation holism**: belief faces "the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body" (the web of belief), and no statement is immune to revision. This is "empiricism without the dogmas".

**Verdict.** The nature of the two dogmas is that both are unearned commitments of logical empiricism's theory of meaning; dismantling individual verificationism removes both at once and yields holism.

**Why this earns marks:** it identifies each dogma exactly, shows *why* Quine calls them identical (the shared verificationism), and lands the positive holistic consequence - the depth a bare "explain the two dogmas" answer usually misses.

### Solved PYQ 9 - 2025 Q4(b), 15 marks

**Question:** "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." Discuss this statement in the light of Quine's 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

**Source metadata:** UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/\\_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](https://upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md).

### Model solution

**Thesis.** The quotation - "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere" - states Quine's **confirmation holism**: because belief confronts experience only as a whole, any statement can be retained under any evidence, provided compensating revisions are made elsewhere in the web (*Two Dogmas of Empiricism*, 1951).

**The web of belief.** Our beliefs form a **field of force** or web whose boundary conditions are experience. A conflict with experience occasions readjustment *somewhere in the interior*, but "the total field is so underdetermined by its boundary conditions ... that there is much latitude of choice as to what statements to re-evaluate". Hence **"no statement is immune to revision"**, and, conversely, any statement can be held true **"come what may"**.

**Why it is true - the Duhem-Quine mechanism.** A hypothesis H predicts an observation O only with auxiliaries A: (H & A) → O. If O fails, logic yields only NOT-(H & A) - *something* in the package is false, but not *which*. So one may always protect H by revising A (or even, at the extreme, by "pleading hallucination" or revising a law of logic). Refutation is never decisive against a single sentence; that is the exact ground of the quotation.

**Consequences.** (i) The analytic/synthetic distinction loses its point - apparent analyticity is just maximal centrality in the web. (ii) There is no sentence-by-sentence verification (the second dogma falls). (iii) The a priori becomes a matter of degree of entrenchment, not of kind.

**Objection and reply.** Does holism license irrationalism - if we may hold anything true, is theory-choice arbitrary? Reply: revision is disciplined by **pragmatic virtues - minimum mutilation**, conservatism, simplicity, generality, fecundity. We *may* save any sentence, but at a rational *cost*; central logical laws are given up only under enormous pressure (cf. the debate over revising logic for quantum mechanics - Birkhoff and von Neumann 1936; Putnam 1968 - and Quine's caution about "change of subject"). So "any statement come what may" describes what is *logically possible*, constrained by what is *pragmatically reasonable*.

**Verdict.** The statement is not a licence for caprice but a precise consequence of holism: experience constrains the web globally, not sentence by sentence, so rational revision is a matter of balancing conservatism against simplicity across the whole system.

**Why this earns marks:** it decodes the quotation as holism, grounds it in the Duhem-Quine mechanism, draws the consequences, and defuses the "anything goes" objection with the pragmatic constraints and a clean verdict.



## ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

### Original Mains 1

Original 10-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Quine and Strawson | Answer in about 150 words

**Question:** Explain how Quine's confirmation holism follows from his rejection of the two dogmas of empiricism.

#### Model solution

**Thesis.** Confirmation holism is the positive residue that remains once both dogmas are removed: with no analytic/synthetic line and no individual verification, belief can face experience only as a whole.

**Argument.** Dogma 1 fails because "analytic" has no non-circular criterion (synonymy, definition, interchangeability *salva veritate*, necessity, semantic rules all presuppose it). Dogma 2 fails because, by the Duhem-Quine point, a hypothesis implies an observation only with auxiliaries: (H & A) → O, so a failed prediction condemns the package, not one sentence. Removing individual verification leaves the **web of belief** meeting "the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body"; hence no statement is immune to revision.

**Verdict.** Holism is not an extra assumption but the direct consequence of denying that sentences have private confirmation-conditions - "empiricism without the dogmas".

**Why this earns marks:** it derives holism rather than asserting it, using the exact mechanism and 1951 source.

### Original Mains 2

Original 15-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Quine and Strawson | Answer in about 250 words

**Question:** "Strawson's persons and Quine's web of belief are two forms of one anti-Cartesian conviction." Critically discuss.

#### Model solution

**Thesis.** The claim is largely true at the level of *temper* - both make the public, not a private inner object, the anchor of thought - but it overstates the case if read as doctrinal identity, for the two differ on the status of the conceptual scheme.

**The convergence.** Strawson's persons are single subjects of P-predicates ascribed to others on **public behavioural criteria**; the private Cartesian ego is rejected as the bearer of meaning. Quine's **web of belief**, resting on behaviourism about the evidence for meaning, likewise denies determinate private meanings (the "museum myth"). Both thus reject the private given: Strawson replaces the private sense-datum with a public spatio-temporal framework, Quine replaces sentence-by-sentence private confirmation with a holistic public science. Each is, in the syllabus phrase, a critic of empiricism's private starting point.

**The divergence (critical).** But the "one conviction" reading hides three differences. (i) *Status*: for Quine the scheme is holistically **revisable** come what may; for Strawson the framework (a public world, re-identifiable subjects, persons) is an **indispensable precondition** of objective thought. (ii) *Meaning*: Quine's is behaviourally **indeterminate**; Strawson's is **fixed** by public criteria. (iii) *Method*: naturalism versus descriptive-transcendental metaphysics.

**Verdict.** The anti-Cartesian, anti-private-object conviction is genuinely shared, and naming it shows synoptic command; but the deeper truth is layered - the periphery of the scheme is Quineanly revisable while some framework role looks Strawsonianly indispensable. So the sentence is a real insight, not an identity.

**Why this earns marks:** it affirms the convergence with exact mechanisms, then critically separates status, meaning and method, closing on a graded verdict.

### Original Mains 3

Original 20-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Quine and Strawson | Answer in about 250 words

**Question:** Assess the claim that both Quine and Strawson refute classical empiricism, but at different levels.

## Model solution

**Thesis.** Both are critics of classical empiricism, but Quine reforms it from *within* its theory of confirmation, whereas Strawson challenges its *starting point*; the two critiques are complementary, and together they leave little of the classical picture standing.

**Quine's internal critique.** Classical empiricism rests on two dogmas: a sharp **analytic/synthetic** distinction and **reductionism** (each statement has its own confirming experiences). Quine dismantles both - analyticity has no non-circular criterion, and by the **Duhem-Quine** point no statement is confirmed in isolation. The result is **confirmation holism**: the **web of belief** faces experience as a corporate body, so "no statement is immune to revision". Crucially Quine *retains* empiricism - experience is still the only check on belief - so his is a reform, "empiricism without the dogmas", not a rejection.

**Strawson's external critique.** Classical empiricism also assumes the **given** is **private, atomic sense-data** from which the public world is constructed. Strawson reverses the dependence: identification and **re-identification** of any particular presuppose a single **public spatio-temporal framework of basic particulars** - material bodies and persons. The private sense-datum is not self-standing but is itself identified only by reference to the public world and its owner. So the empiricist *starting point* is incoherent as a foundation.

**Assessment.** The critiques operate at different levels - theory of confirmation versus theory of the given - and are mutually reinforcing: Quine removes the epistemic scaffolding, Strawson removes the foundation. **Objection:** Grice and Strawson resist Quine's overreach on analyticity, and a defender of sense-data may deny that identification needs a public framework. **Reply:** even granting these, the burden has shifted decisively onto the empiricist.

**Verdict.** Empiricism survives only as Quine's holistic, dogma-free version; the classical private-atomistic form is refuted at both levels.

**Why this earns marks:** it distinguishes the two levels precisely, gives each thinker's exact mechanism, weighs a named objection, and returns a clear graded verdict.